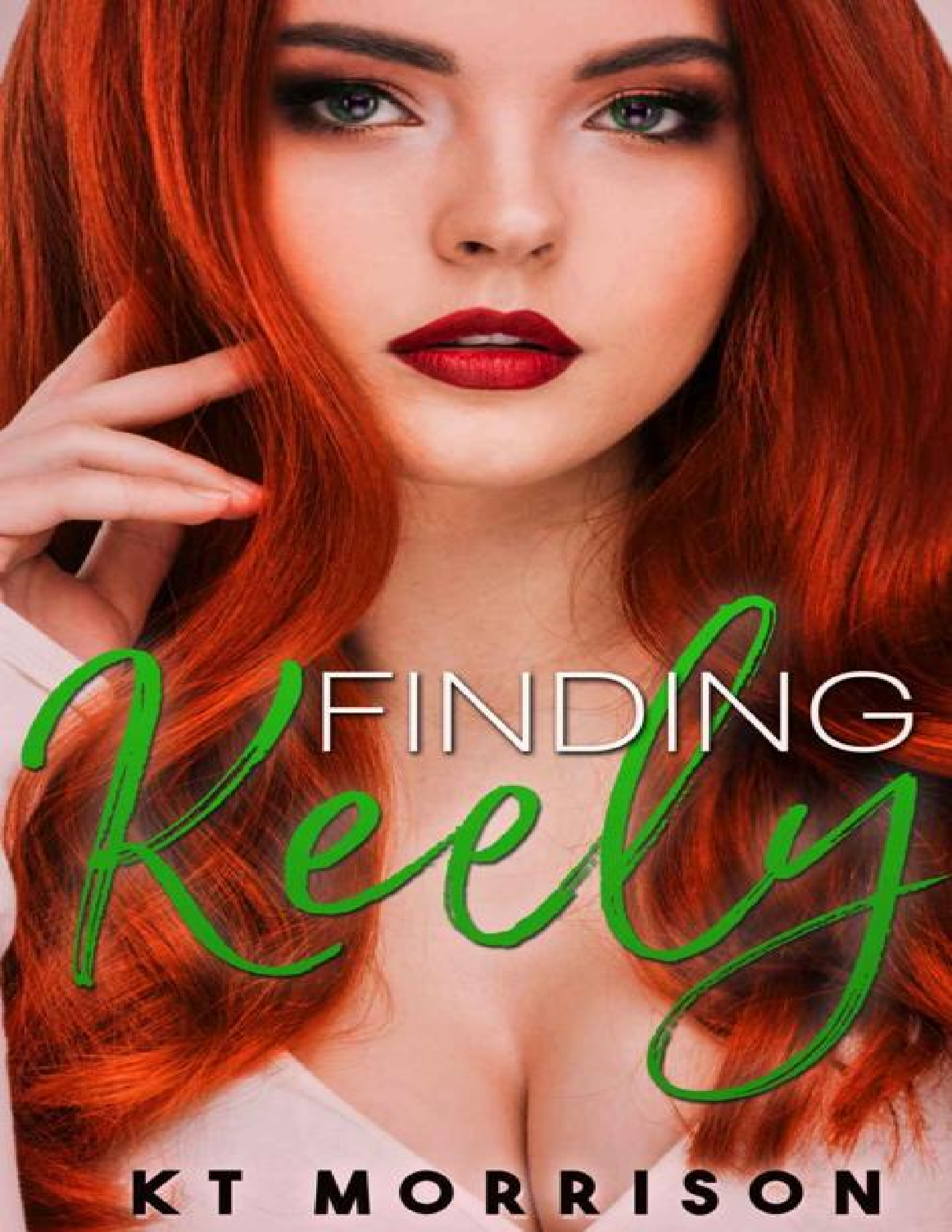




FINDING
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KT MORRISON

FINDING KEELY

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

Visit My Website!

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SERIES

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Mary's Pledge

ANTHOLOGIES

The Taken Anthology

This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

FINDING KEELY

A **KEELY** book

40,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

PART 1

Solo

OCTOBER 17 - NOVEMBER 4

Aughrim Arms

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 17

AT THE AUGHRIM Arms on the Ballinaclesh Road, Keely O'Mearáin conversed via text with the world's most untrustworthy asshole, almost five-thousand kilometers away in the sleazy city of Boston. It was her Nan's eighty-eighth birthday party and the last thing she needed right now was to hear lame explanations from Derek. Still, he texted.

Derek: What did she say?

Keely: I don't want to talk about it

Derek: Just tell me

Keely: I'll talk when I get back I'm with me Nan

The phone buzzed one more time as she struggled to get it back into her purse without looking at the screen. Checked it anyway, turning it to face her before it disappeared into her handbag.

Derek: She's a liar

Sure she is Derek, but why would she lie? You're cheating on me and I know it.

Enough of that though. She was home in Aughrim, with her family, with her sisters and her brother, with her best mates Sara and Marly. American Derek and all his two-faced bullshit could take a hike because tonight she would have fun without him.

Now she rejoined the party celebrating her Nan's eightieth birthday. She saw her now, the queen matriarch in her wheelchair, tartan blanket over her knees, Keely's mother draping her arms over her own mother's shoulders. Someone took a picture. Keely joined them, shouting over the din: "Can I get in on that?"

Her mom beamed. "Get over here." She waved her hand in a circle and Keely bounced herself in place; took her spot in the Keely family matriarchy. Beloved Nan in the center, just like she was the master of the family, her dear mother on the other side. They got their faces together as close as they could. Three similar faces in various stages of age. Her hair bright and bouncing in orange, her mother's tied back and dark red now. And Nan's once fiery locks gone silver and tucked behind her ears in a bun with tortoiseshell clips.

Taking the picture was her cousin Michael. He said, "Aw, well that one's the winner," as he looked at the viewfinder.

Her mom went to approve it. She always had final say.

Keely knelt and patted her nan's shoulder. "Excellent party, eh, Nan?" she shouted over the music. Someone had hired a fiddler and bodhran duo. There was dancing and drinking.

Her nan said, "I'm so glad you're here, Keely. All of you." She patted her granddaughter's cheek.

Keely said, "I just wish that Da could make it."

"Did you expect him to?"

"Aye. No, I didn't."

"He's an important man. Always busy. But he made some beautiful daughters and they're what I paid to see."

Nan had paid for her plane ticket from Boston. Paid for Nora's train ticket from Dublin, and Colleen's from London. She would've paid Keely's father's plane trip from Qatar but the man could afford it himself. He just couldn't afford the time.

"Happy birthday, Nan," she said again, and kissed the woman's head, holding it a long time. They hugged, she told her nan she'd be back, and

joined Marly at the bar who was waving her over with something important to say.

“What is it?”

Marly said, “David’s here.”

“Yeah, I expected he might.”

“Don’t you want to talk to him?”

“God, that was a long time ago.”

“He’s more handsome.”

“What do I care?”

“You used to care a lot,” she said and nudged her with an elbow.

“I used to a lot of things,” she said and ordered herself another water. One year sober, and as much as this was the perfect occasion to break it, she wouldn’t.

As she took a sip, a familiar voice behind her said, “As I live and breathe.”

She turned, said, “Ah, a delivery from the House of Clichés. I wonder what I tip the man...”

David Sloane was there, smiling, holding a glass of single malt. Clipped fingernails, trimmed beard now. It showed off his rugged square jaw. Still tall, looking around six-three, filled out now to man-size. It was too bad he’d been an asshole to her because boy did he look good.

David said, “Back from the Middle East?”

“Me? You know that’s not where I am.”

“Do I not?”

“That’s rich. Like if I said to you, How’s the car mechanic business?”

“I’m not a mechanic.”

“Oh? I thought you always liked cars.”

“I’m not a mechanic, Keely.” *There was that arrogance.*

“I heard you’d gone to work at a Volkswagen dealer.”

Firm, defiant voice: “I’m a barrister.”

“Oh, news to me.”

He rolled his eyes. “All right, very funny.”

“You see what I mean? Am I in the Middle East? You know I’m in America.”

“Oh? What you doing there?”

She set her glass down, gave her ex-teen-lover a stony gaze. “Tell you what I’m not doing, David. Playing games,” she said, left, walked

underneath his wide, dimpled chin and showed him her back.

In the double-door vestibule that led out onto the Ballinaclash Road she stopped and looked out at the town's main street. It was pissing rain. Here she thought she'd come out for some fresh air, and there was none to be had. Not even an awning on this five-hundred-year-old dump.

The doors opened behind her, and it was Billy from the Bray Academy, the private school she'd gone to here near Aughrim. A friendly face as homely as it may be.

He said, "Hey, Keels, you're not going are you?"

"Just need fresh air, Billy."

"Aye, I hear that," he said, and he waved his hand, and the next thing Justino, the Italian Irishman joined them. He was a black-haired Roman who immigrated when he was eleven; his clashing dialects of childhood Italian and teenage English warped by Gaelic made him usually unintelligible. But he had his charms.

Now it was three of them crammed in the small space, her with her hands in her pockets, and these two blokes with big pints of Stella. They lounged on the walls, looking at her, drunk as shites.

She smiled, "How've you been?"

"Aye, we're doing all right, Keels. Right as we can be, not as good as you, not off in the land of machine guns."

"It's a little all right. I have to wear a bulletproof vest, but I tell you what, I'm a crack shot now, I could knock that pint of beer off your head from across the street." She put her hand in her pocket and pointed her finger at him through it. She leaned her back against the glass door, kept her trigger finger on them like she was holding them at bay.

Billy said, "Where you going?"

Justino said, "It's fuckin' hoorin' out there, girl."

"Going out for fresh air," she sang.

Justino said, "Aye, 'mon, stay wi' us, Keels."

Billy said, "You'll drown out there."

"I'm an excellent swimmer," she shouted as she walked out and felt herself drenched in a heartbeat.

The two of them came to the door and held it open, afraid to come out, but extending their hands like they wanted to pull her back in...

Lampoon

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 20

IT WAS COMING along Holyoke out front of Lowell House she ran into Cole. He was on a bicycle with a duffel bag slung on his back; skinny gray cords and a fisherman's sweater. Desert boot up on a concrete bollard for balance while he stayed on the bike's saddle, he asked her about the dress slung over her shoulder shrouded in cling wrap. "High Table," she told him; her special invite to a faculty dinner where the Massachusetts governor would be seated three settings away on her right-hand side.

"Oh, shit, congrats," he said, then: "It's not this weekend, is it?"

"Always Mondays," she said of her residential house's High Table tradition.

"Yeah, that's right," he said, showing relief. "You can come out with us this weekend?"

"Come out where?"

"I don't know, no big deal... Brew Hall?"

"Yeah, sure, sounds good," she said, always feeling a little uncomfortable alone with him, his girlfriend Maggie not around, given their past.

He asked her: "How was your grandma's party?"

"Wild," she said, "Nan drank a whole bottle of whiskey and got in a fist fight."

Cole frowned, caught between laughing and believing her. "Did she?"

"No, come on. Not my sweet Nan. It was nice. I saw my brother and sisters, my friends... It was a great dinner, and it sure made her happy seeing us all together."

“I’ll bet.”

“You guys had fun without me?”

Cole smirked. “We stayed in.”

“I know, I was texting her.”

Now he nodded, arms folded while he looked down at where his boot curled over the edge of chipped concrete. “Sorry, you know, to hear about Derek.”

“It’s not over,” she said defensively, not liking his sullen expression over the demise of her relationship. It made her feel like a loser.

“It’s not?” Cole looked surprised, and now she was embarrassed.

“Derek doesn’t think so, at least. Calling me every day,” she said.

He smiled and watched her through narrowed eyes. *Fuck, he was handsome.* Cole said, “You’re way too good for him.”

“Platitudes,” she said, averting her eyes now as well and watching the toe of her loafer pinch a stone against the sidewalk and scrape an arc.

Cole said, “I know that guy. You can do better.”

Aye, she’d had Cole at one time—though that was just sex, wasn’t it? “Well, thanks for saying it, but I thought he was quite a catch. Don’t you think he’s handsome?”

Cole laughed, eyes closing, chin nodding forward. She liked to make him laugh. “He’s a stud, I admit it.”

She said, “Yeah, that’s more like it.”

“Okay—but you can still do better.” Then a thought came to him and he sought to communicate it, opening his hands up so she could see his palms—the big picture. “You *deserve* better,” he said, dragging out ‘deserve’ for full weighted effect.

“I appreciate the sentiment,” she said, folding her evening dress over her arm now and leaning on the wooden railway tie that connected the concrete bollards. “You know it was your Maggie got me the High Table...?”

“She did?”

“I suspect she did. I see one of the prestigious guests is a gentleman named Martin Becker. Ever heard of him?”

“I know him well,” he said, eyes narrowed again, a certain comical smugness relaxing his features. “High Table’s about connections, sounds like you’ve already got ‘em.”

She stood upright now, checked her watch. She had class in a half hour and she had to get her dress into her closet first. "I'll have to thank her on Friday."

Cole set his feet on the pedals again, shifted his bag so it sat on the small of his back and put his hands on the bar. Before easing away, he stopped again. "Hey, that guy we always talk about, Max, fellow Farm alum...? He's coming this weekend, you finally get to meet him."

She flashed a polite and happy smile, he waved, then pedaled off toward the Lampoon, and she called out, "See you on Friday," and headed into Lowell.

She hustled below the bell tower and was on the D stairs between the third and fourth floor when she realized she just got set up with Maggie and Cole's friend Max.

Vanity

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23

AT HER ROOMMATE'S VANITY, Keely blow dried her hair. Martina was a Mennonite, or her family was, and she loved ancestral treasures. This mirrored vanity with matching chair were made by her great-grandfather in Pennsylvania. Probably not really a vanity, given they were Mennonites and eschewed vanity, but it was a sideboard with a knee-hole, and Martina'd brought a mirror that rested on it leaning against the wall. It was a beautiful piece of furniture in an otherwise sparse room. Even though it had hosted two Hollywood celebrities before they were celebrities it was a grim space and needed the liveliness of Martina's antique treasures.

Martina came in with folded laundry, set it down on her bed, and sat to watch Keely get beautiful. When the dryer was shut off, she said, "I haven't seen you smile like this all week."

"Sure you have," Keely said.

"Not like this."

"I was just thinking of something funny."

Martina smiled and sat deeper on her bed, kicking off her slippers. "I'm glad you're doing okay."

Keely said, "I'm queen of the bounce-back."

Martina laughed, drew her feet to rest on the edge of the bed. She had moisturizer on her night table and she pumped two squirts into her hands to massage her feet.

Keely said, "I think I'm being set up tonight."

"Some kind of criminal caper—a heist?"

Keely laughed. "A heist of the heart, I imagine."

“Of the heart? Who is it?”

She said, “You know Cole and Maggie?”

“Uh-huh, your weird old friends.”

“They’re not old.”

Martina considered it, being polite, looking up at the ceiling, but then saying: “Aren’t they married and have their own house?”

“No. Not really. Anyway, Maggie has a friend...”

“Who’s the friend?”

“Another guy from Farmingham.”

“It’s like some kind of secret society around here.”

“Secret societies aren’t what you think in Vermont.”

“A secret hiking society,” Martina laughed.

“That was about it.”

“You prefer the bustle of the city.”

“Farm was okay. Anyway, this guy’s a friend of theirs from school. They’re always talking about him and now he’s coming this weekend. They made sure to invite me.”

Martina considered it, using her index finger to squish lotion between her toes.

“What?...” Keely asked her, noting her roommate’s sullen expression.

“I like Derek.”

“He’s all yours then.”

“Not like that,” Martina said and rolled her eyes in exaggerated annoyance. It was defensive; it didn’t take an F.B.I. profiler to detect the crush Martina had on handsome, dark-haired, six-foot-two Derek Armstrong.

Keely said, “I told you...”

Martina sighed, trying to salvage something she thought had value. “Did you talk to him?”

“What’s there to talk about?” she said, “I told you already. He can’t even deny it.” She was pushing blush on her cheeks now with the brush.

Martina said, “Derek seems so nice.”

“They’re the worst ones,” she said, now doing the other cheek.

“Well,” Martina shrugged, “like I said, I do like to see you smile again.”

“Possibilities always make me smile.”

“Me too,” Martina said, laying back and putting her head on the pillow. She opened her laptop.

There were scant few possibilities for Martina, her parents didn't allow her to date. If she wanted to live vicariously through her roommate, there wasn't much wrong with it—but she wouldn't last two minutes on a date with a man like Derek.

Her phone chirped, and she swiveled it to see the screen, then held it up and close for Martina to read the name calling: DEREK, overtop a picture of his handsome mug she'd taken when they were at the night club Tunnel in the W Hotel. Her bad-boy ex lit up in pulsing purple that had wavered with the boom of the DJ's beat. The effect left him looking demonic; or, more accurately, devilish, because he was darkly handsome.

Martina scooted to the edge of the bed, her expression enthralled at the prospect of being present for a development in the Derek-Keely saga. But Keely nodded her head sideways, indicating their dorm room door.

"Oh, come on," Martina pleaded.

"Privacy, *please*..." Keely pleaded in return. "Two minutes."

Martina stood reluctantly, her posture stooped. Her moisturized feet skidded on their floor and she giggled as she stuck them in her slippers then shuffled to the door. She lingered as she backed out, and Keely brushed her away with the backs of her fingers and answered the phone. Martina scowled with a smile and closed the door behind her.

"Yes, Derek, what is it?"

"Why are you avoiding me?"

"What makes you think that?"

"Oh, I don't know, probably all the times you've avoided me."

"It's been a busy week."

"How was Ireland?"

"What do you care?"

"You know I care, Keely. Are you doing this just to be difficult?"

She scoffed at the notion. "Difficult—me? I think I made things easy for you, didn't I? Maybe too easy because you ended up in another girl's bed or she in yours."

"Why do you say that?"

"You're done with the denying then? How many stages are there in guilt?"

"I'm not guilty."

"You're a liar."

"Meet me and say that."

“You want to be the tough guy?”

“I mean look in my eyes, Keely.”

“I’ve looked in your eyes many’s a time, Derek, and I always saw it there, but now it’s confirmed.”

“You always thought I was a cheater?”

“You told me you were. Your exes said you were...”

“Of course *they* say that...”

She vibrated her head like it was going to explode, rolling her eyes up like she was possessed, a frustrated roar trying to burst from her. She clenched her jaw, relaxed it, said, “It’s all right, I cheated on you, too.”

“Oh, really? That’s not like you.”

“Isn’t it? You pushed me there. It was me Nan’s party, and I was drinking.”

“You don’t drink like that, Keely...”

“I used to—and I do when I’m at home. I do when someone I trust has been lying to me and I’m washing away my woes. And I’d like to point out while it’s not like me, it’s certainly like you. You set the pace, so you can’t complain when I catch up.”

“Come on, Keely, just meet me...”

“It was two guys.”

“Keely... So you cheated on me twice?”

“It’s not cheatin’ when we’re broken up. And I only cheated on you once.”

“What are you saying?”

“It’s a real math problem, isn’t it? Don’t worry though, it’s all primary numbers.”

“Two guys at the same time? Please, Keely, just meet me...”

“I’m too busy.”

“Can I make an appointment?”

“Being aloof isn’t endearing you to me at all. Good night, all right, Derek? I’m going on a date tonight and I’m trying to get ready.”

“Are you dating two guys tonight?”

“You don’t date two guys at once, Derek,” she said kindly. “You do fuck them all night though—you know you lack endurance, and I certainly showed these two strapping lads how pleased I was to get what I’ve been missing. We took a lot of pictures, if you bug me again I’ll share them with you.” She hung up and tossed her phone to the back of the dresser with a

satisfying clatter. Derek would call back, but she was in the mood to ignore him now.

First Impressions

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23

THE BREW HALL wasn't exactly a Harvard bar, but it was in Harvard Square. Mostly populated by urbanites, the sight of students was rare. It suited Maggie and Cole who were unlike most students she knew. Martina saying they were a married couple didn't seem far off, really, though they weren't. Both of them were three years older than her, third-year law students graduating next spring, Maggie heading to the graduate program the following fall to get her M., and Cole already with a good job lined up at a fund in Rhode Island. They had a house together and lived like a married couple; it wouldn't be long till they were hitched, she figured.

They were twenty-three and at a different life stage than her and the reason she found herself in a position to hang out with them was because Maggie had been a mentor last year when she enrolled in a pre-JD prep group. She'd originally been paired with another law student, but once Maggie found out that they'd both gone to Farmingham they switched. Maggie was impressive; a good role model for her and an amazing mentor. Once the program was over they didn't stop hanging out. It was pretty confirmed they were official friends now.

She arrived at the pub at eight o'clock. The place was packed. A classy kind of joint although a little loud for dinner; it was lit by low hanging globes the size of basketballs over the tables, a second series of similar lights about six feet above, making the gloss on the oak-paneled walls shine; the clientele was older; couples in their thirties and well-dressed. Probably expensive, and while she had money to pay, Maggie usually picked up the tab when they went out together.

A hand waved to her from the crowd; Maggie sat in a banquette with padded green leather seating across from the bar, her back to a half wall that separated the drinks area from the restaurant. Keely smiled and pointed a finger at her, wove through a passing bunch and came to join Maggie at the table. She slid in beside, grabbed her wrist and they kissed cheeks.

Keely said, "You're shivering."

"Am I?"

Keely put her hand higher on Maggie's forearm. "Are you cold?"

Maggie hunched her shoulders up and said, "Yeah, I guess I am."

Keely picked up her menu, said, "It's so warm in here."

"I just arrived. I walked from the house."

"Aye, I came from Lowell, it's cold out there."

"I'll warm up," Maggie said, hands rubbing up and down her upper arms.

She'd decided on a one-drink maximum moving forward, so she perused the bar menu carefully to see what she would order. A nice loosener, something to get her mouth moving. Eyes still scanning the bar menu, she asked, "Is Cole coming?"

Maggie sipped a glass of wine. "Yeah, he's on his way. Should be here any minute."

Casually: "And your friend?"

Maggie sipped again, touched two fingers to her chest. She wore a low V-neck sweater and a button-down shirt but she touched just above her collarbone where her skin was bare. She cleared her throat. "Yes, he's coming, too."

"That's good," Keely sighed like she couldn't care less one way or the other whether this guy showed up or not. Then she thumped her menu down, remembering something. She said, "I told you I got High Table..."

"Yes, you did."

"I was looking at the roster. I'm sitting at a table with Martin Becker. I googled him. That's your dad."

"Yes, my father does High Table once every decade."

"Is that how I got High Table?"

Maggie smiled like she didn't want to answer, averted her eyes then saw Cole coming in through the front doors. "Hey, Cole's here." She lifted off her seat a little and waved him over.

He made his way through the crowd, eyes locked on their table, giving them a crushingly handsome smile. The guy attracted everyone's attention, even some of the guys. When he reached them, he set himself down on the far side of Maggie. He leaned across her, though, and kissed Keely's cheek, saying, "Good to see you."

"Thanks for inviting me."

They went out almost every weekend since they came back to school this year. They'd hung out a few times at the end of the last school year, and Maggie was quick to get them reunited once Keely came back from Ireland. But even during the summer break, Maggie had stayed in touch. She was turning into a good friend despite their age differences.

She asked Maggie: "How's class—?... Oh wait, how's the thing with Professor Winghammer? He come around?"

"Oh, it's good. We straightened it out."

Cole waved the waiter over, said, "Yeah, she straightened that guy out. He's on Team Maggie now."

"That's good," Keely said.

"We're all on Team Maggie," he said and put an arm around her, lounging back in the banquette and smiling. Maggie rolled her eyes again, leaned over and caressed his chest and kissed his chin. "Where were you?" she asked him.

"Jacobson kept me late, and then I was on the phone, standing in the park talking to Hartley."

"Westlake? What did he want?"

"You know—chit-chat. He didn't *want* anything."

The waiter was there now, and they ordered their drinks. Maggie took another wine, Cole a beer. She ordered an old-fashioned, double.

Now Keely put both her elbows on the table and caressed the back of her arms, giving her friends a sly sort of smile. "And what does your friend Max like to drink?"

Cole smiled but she could see Maggie flinch.

Cole answered. "Max *was* a beer guy. Who knows now. He doesn't have that student budget anymore, his tastes are elevated."

"Wine snob?"

Cole shrugged, said, "Max's been working hard. He does buy-side in Manhattan."

She turned her nose up. "Ew, a Finance Bro."

Maggie scoffed. “Hardly.”

“I was kidding.” She nudged Maggie’s knee with her own.

The worry with a finance bro was real, though—she might be in for a night of talking about boats and cars and vacations and all the dumb assholes Max works with and fucks over, and probably golf or some fucking thing. Little dick kyoodling; a scared little boy thrashing around in grown-up clothes, wielding inflated tales of their great successes like studded weapons and all he’s worried about is someone getting close and finding out he didn’t fuck anywhere near as many sorority girls he claims, at least not sober ones, and please don’t look in my underwear, and please pet my head while I cry myself to sleep because I’m not the man I boast to be. But they wouldn’t be friends with a guy like that, would they?

Cole said, “He’s an independent guy. He works at a good company.”

She said, “And he’s a good person?”

Maggie nodded and murmured, “The best.”

Cole looked troubled but gave her a shake, hugging her with his arm.

“Yeah, he’s the best. He’s our best friend.”

“Yeah,” she said, “you’re always talking about him.”

“He comes up almost every weekend. Depending on the season.”

“How come I’ve never met him before?”

Cole said, “Yeah, it’s weird your paths haven’t crossed.”

“Well, he’s a good friend of yours so I’m excited to meet him.”

The waiter arrived in his neat shirt and tie behind a burgundy apron. He set their glasses down and she took a nice heavy drag. It was the perfect coldness, enough to squint one eye. Maggie still looked sullen and didn’t touch her drink.

She asked her, “You sure you’re okay?”

Cole gave Maggie another shake. “She’s okay.”

“Can you excuse me?” Maggie asked. “I think I need to go to the bathroom.”

It was funny to see Maggie without a smile. The girl was perpetually happy. It would be hard not to be, on Cole’s arm. The guy had the looks of a male model but he was smart and funny. Driven, too, good at what he did. They shared a house together just outside Harvard Square, they were always cooking and kissing. It was heartwarming but kind of sickening at times, too. It was what anybody would want.

Cole slipped out, helped Maggie get to her feet, and she went to the bathroom, weaving through the bar crowd and disappearing down a corridor. Cole slid in again, taking Maggie's spot to sit next to her.

Keely told him: "She was shivering."

"Yes, I think she's cold."

"She might be coming down with something."

"Nah, she's just got a lot going on."

"Is it bad?"

Cole's eyes looked around the room and she realized he was coming up with something to say. He said, "Just stuff at home."

Well, that was a lie. First thing she thought was: *Holy shit!—Maggie is pregnant. There goes her last year of the JD. She and Cole didn't time it right, now here she was...*

She took another sip of her Old-fashioned, worried now. Cole seemed happy, though, so whatever it was they would work it out. They were too smart not to. Maggie's family, by all accounts, was loaded. It's not exactly like she would have her life ruined, pushing a stroller around some seedy Boston neighborhood worried about the price of formula. She brightened. "I hope she's okay."

"Yes, she will be." They sat in silence and watched the crowd. He said, "Lotta yuppies here tonight."

"I don't see *anybody* I know."

She said fuck it and ordered herself another drink. Knocked the first one back before the second was even poured. Then Maggie was returning to them from the bathroom, and there was that smile again. Her cheeks were rosy though, and it wasn't impossible she was throwing up in the toilet.

Cole slipped out of the banquette to let her get in. He flashed his phone to Maggie said, "Max is here now."

Maggie made a strange expression, a sort of grimace. She said, "Where is he?"

"He's on Mt. Auburn."

Maggie pushed herself out of the banquette again. She said, "I better go meet him."

Cole said quietly: "Go meet him. Bring him in."

They stopped, Maggie looking up into Cole's eyes. They kissed, and she watched Cole's masculine hand give Maggie's upper arm a squeeze. He whispered in her ear.

Now Maggie was turning, smiling, but her eyes were wet. She said to Keely, “I’ll be right back.”

“Okay,” she said, waving the waiter closer because she needed that second drink he was supposed to be bringing.

ONE LOOK at this guy Max and she knew he was her type. Not at all what she expected—she expected another Cole, but not as polished; some salesman-smile guy, handsome and dashing; armed with a commanding presence, he’d always look to master everyone he met.

But this Max was her type.

He came in with Maggie; a man of average height and wearing a dark corduroy jacket and a black button-down shirt open at the neck. He had his hands in his jacket pockets and his shoulders hunched up high. Expression: sullen, brooding. Again, just her type. Black wavy hair, soulful eyes, soft, pouting, cherry lips. He didn’t look like a Finance Bro at all. He looked like he taught poetry and fucked college girls, singing them stanzas in his parlor to get their clothes off. She couldn’t help smiling at the unexpected visage on Maggie’s arm.

Even Cole was excited. “Hey, there he is,” he said to her, “This is Max.”

He scooted out again, held a hand for his friend. Max rejected it, came in and gave him a big hug. They embraced, and Cole slapped Max’s back.

Keely stayed seated, improved her posture and waited to be introduced. It was Maggie who did it, coming behind Max and putting a hand on his back. She gestured toward Keely but then couldn’t speak. Cole was quick to finish: “Max, this is our friend Keely. She starts law next year.”

Max didn’t smile, looked at her and gave a polite sort of head nod. He reached across the table and shook her hand. His hand was warm, and she gave him a precious smile.

Max said to Cole, “Oh, right. She went to Farmingham.”

“Yeah,” Cole said, “that’s right, that’s how we know her. Maggie was her mentor last year in a JD prep program. They’ve been hanging out since then.”

Keely said, “And you’re Max. Their mysterious friend who lives in the arcane financial maze of Manhattan, pushing money around inside

computers”—she touched the rim of her glass and ran her index finger in a circle around the lip—“but dresses like a poet.”

And there he was. There was the Max deep inside that liked to smile. He had his hands in his pockets again, and he opened the flaps of his jacket outward to look down at what he wore. He said, “You don’t like my outfit?”

She said, “You’re just not what I expected.”

He smiled. “More of a sweater over the shoulders kinda guy?”

She couldn’t help but laugh. “Yeah, you know what?—exactly that.”

“That’s how I dress in the city. Show up in Boston like that you get your face punched in.”

Cole slapped him on the back, put a hand out to guide him to sit next to Keely. She moved her purse to the other side. Now she was sandwiched; Max next to her, and Maggie on her other side. Cole filled out the other end of their banquette crescent.

Two-Seater

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23

FOR DINNER she had the pan-seared salmon with quinoa and cherries, and they conversed. She played it cool, but holy shit this Max guy played it cooler. She started to think that this guy didn't even know she was going to be there. It was a puzzle. Intriguing, just the same. Perhaps she *wasn't* being set up. Perhaps they didn't think she was good enough for Max. They talked about him so highly. But then again, maybe they were just introducing her to the circle of friends they had. Broadening her scope in their relationship. It would be a good thing to be with them. She never didn't have fun. It was a bit of a hurdle getting Maggie over the hump that she had slept with Cole in her first year at Farmingham. That was a shaky time. She was working on a friendship with Maggie, who was always talking about her boyfriend. Had never referred to him as Cole, only as her boyfriend. She was at the house with Maggie, sitting at the kitchen table, then this guy comes in... and while she knew her boyfriend was from Farmingham what were the chances that it would be a guy she had slept with? Well, she slept with a few guys; it wasn't entirely out of the realm of possibilities. *But Cole Cantarella?* She couldn't hide it when she saw him; her reaction was impossible to ignore. Cole's too. The two of them locked eyes and Cole did this stumbling inadvertently comic routine, his confident stride turning into a trudge by the time he made it to shake her hand. What would he have thought, coming in to the kitchen to see your girlfriend sitting with a former lover?—must have thought it was some kind of setup, that Maggie was mad at him. Maggie noted the reaction between them—she was a smart cookie—and she didn't even need to ask. Totally knew. Maggie said: This is Keely, the one from

Farmingham I was telling you about. Her voice was quiet, awkward; her cheeks had blushed. They just all three admitted to knowing each other at Farmingham and Maggie filled in the rest.

But Maggie and Cole had been together for quite a while, and you probably didn't have to know Cole for long to know that he had no problems finding girls to fill his bedroom. If you were going to settle down with a guy like Cole, you had to have confidence. And Maggie was confident. That night Cole left them alone and went upstairs. She called their study session short because the quiet at the kitchen table was excruciating.

The next time she saw Maggie, Maggie was over it. She didn't mention it all, and they were back to square one, back to being burgeoning friends again. She'd always wondered if Cole had admitted it later. Tried to picture if Maggie was a dish-smashing type or not. Did Maggie confront him? Did they slam doors and give each other the cold shoulder? She didn't want to know. They'd got over it, anyway.

When dinner was over, they ordered dessert. She had to be careful because she was prone to putting on the weight. Especially during the school year. But with two double Old-fashionedes in her belly, her resolve was low, and she asked Max if he wanted to split something. He didn't want the chocolate cake like she did. She tried to accommodate him by finding out what he wanted to eat for dessert, but she didn't want coconut cream pie even if it *was* served in a glass jar. They all skipped sweets.

It was kind of weird. By the end of dinner she was pretty sure she *wasn't* being set up. Didn't mean she wasn't interested though. The guy was funny but cynical, smart and adorable. And simmering under that lowered brow she knew there was despair and hurt and darkness. And just like she loved a good mystery book she wanted to flip to his back page and find out whodunit.

MAX PAID FOR DINNER. Even paid for her though she brought money out. They did that thing where she insisted but he wouldn't even listen to her. It was kind of cute, and under different circumstances would've been funny. But she kind of wanted to pay. Didn't want this guy to have this

leverage over her. It was like he was paying for her dinner but only because she tagged along. Not because he had any interest in her or cared about her. They weren't even friends yet. It was just the polite thing to do. He looked at her warmly and said *Oh no, please, it's on me*, and she should put her purse away. In the end, he got his way, flashing out his credit card and tapping for the whole meal at once. Then they were standing, and it looked like Max was ready to say good night. She asked, *Oh, where are you staying?* and then wanted to hoist that one back. Boy, it was terrible to just blurt out a query where someone was going to be getting naked and lying down. *Could you be more obvious?* But she didn't even want to sleep with him. It wasn't that at all. It was an honest question. She buttoned her lip and caught a flashing eye-stab from Maggie.

Cole said, "He stays with us. He's coming back to the house. We're all coming back to the house. One more round."

Max raised his eyebrows. "Oh yeah? Keely's coming?"

She said, "Sounds like I was invited," making it sound a little colder than she intended.

Max did that hands in pocket thing again, his brow coming low and that somber expression returning. He said, "Oh yeah, no, that's cool." Then instantly brightening, added: "Hey, I brought a port. It's in the car."

Maggie said, "Perfect. Okay, we're going to walk. You drive over."

Cole said, "Hey, you just got that two-seater. Take Keely with you."

She said, "I could walk."

Maggie's face was pained, and she wondered what was bothering her. Maggie said, "Take Keely for a drive. We'll meet you at the house." It was like she was earnest to say it, but her words moved slow as molasses.

Cole took Maggie's hand, and Max said to her, "Yeah, come on with me. We'll sit on their door stoop and wait for their slow-walking asses to catch up."

"We're just around the corner," Cole said smiling, Maggie, too, though wanly.

Max led the way, and she trotted to catch up with him. She walked one step behind and to his side, but he held the door for her and they walked out into the cold night air together. She waited for him, standing on the sidewalk letting him catch up now. He turned up the collar of his jacket and they walked side by side along the sidewalk.

She said, "You thought it was just going to be the three of you?"

“Hey, it’s fine. Sorry about that, my mind was elsewhere. I didn’t mean to be weird.”

“I hang out with them every weekend now.”

“Yeah, I do, too.”

“Funny we haven’t met before.”

“I don’t always come on Fridays.”

She shrugged her shoulders and said, “I thought maybe they were keeping us apart.”

“Some sort of conspiracy?”

“They’re always up to something.”

“They are schemers,” Max agreed.

Now she started to smile, her teeter-totter rising up towards liking him again. Then he introduced her to his car. A Porsche. Figures. He popped the alarm, and the lights flashed. She saw the gold shield on the hood and rolled her eyes internally. But then the guy held the door for her. Didn’t show off his car, didn’t act like it was a big deal. When she got in she realized it wasn’t a new Porsche. Leather seats were worn with frequent sliding bums, faint tracing lines through the black leather. Dashboard gauges were dials, not digital.

When Max got in the driver’s seat she said, “Is this an old car?”

He snuffled laughter, slipping a key in the ignition. “Is that okay?”

“No, sorry, I just meant what year is it?”

“A ’96. Best year of my life.”

She asked: “What happened?”

Eyes out the front, he said absently, “Year I was born. Most problem-free year ever.”

It took three starts for it to go, but then he was merging out into traffic, weaving through Harvard Square, getting into West Cambridge, turning right on Hilliard. He honked the horn at the two passing figures holding hands and talking close. Maggie and Cole waved back. Then he was turning in the driveway, shutting it down. She didn’t wait for him to get the door because that would feel silly (and he seemed like the kind of guy who might do it). She got out on her own, and they wandered to the end of the driveway and waited for Cole and Maggie without saying anything. Soon as his friends were nearer, Max loosened up again and was smiling.

Tamer

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23

COLE AND MAGGIE had their own house, though she always assumed it belonged to Maggie. The two of them lived like husband and wife in a cute two-story federal with an attic and a tiny garden squared off by a white picket fence. The houses on Hilliard butted right up to the red-brick sidewalks and were all a few hundred years old, but renovated and well-kept; Maggie and Cole's in a pale yellow with white trim.

Max and Cole stood behind her on the stoop while they waited for Maggie to open the door. Then they were in, finding the place warm. Max doffed his corduroy suit jacket, went into the kitchen like he was familiar with the place, paper bag tucked under his arm. At the kitchen table he withdrew a squat burgundy bottle of port from the paper bag and set it down, rotating it around so everyone could look at the label. Maggie slipped her shoes off in the hall and held onto Cole's arm for support. Max went to the kitchen cupboards, opening the right one to find port glasses. He brought out four and set them next to the bottle. Cole went into the living room and put a record on the turntable. Soon they were listening to Strauss, and they all went into the living room together with their glasses of port. Cole corralled Max so he was forced to sit next to her.

Now they were side-by-side on the couch, her with her legs crossed and sipping a glass of port. This was drink number three. And the first two were doubles. She had to be wary.

While Cole and Maggie got close to talk, Max asked her, "So you know Maggie through some JD program?"

“I start law next year, and there’s a sort of fast-track program of mentorship where they hook you up with existing students. Maggie was a mentor, found out I went to Farmingham and she switched partners with somebody else. We exchanged stories about Vermont.”

“Yeah, Vermont was a blast.”

“What did you major in?”

Max said, “Government and policy.”

“But you’re in Manhattan?”

“Yeah, I know—it’s not what I intended, but it just feels right, anyway.”

“You like finance?”

“No. But it’s like a puzzle. It’s like a game. I like that.”

“I get it.”

“How about you?” he asked her, “What are you doing now?”

“Government.”

“What a coincidence.”

“Then next year I’ll start my JD.”

Max sipped his port, watching her. He said, “And what do you want to do?”

She’d been busted. She snarled, showed her teeth and shrugged. “I don’t even know.”

Max laughed.

“What...?” She laughed too.

He said, “Like me. Who knows what you’ll end up doing.”

She took a sip of the port, smiled and said, “You know... I always wanted to be a lion tamer. You think I might do that?”

“Yeah, that would be pretty great. You could maybe take some whip-cracking classes at community college, fill out your CV.”

“You know what,” she said, “that’s a great idea. I should look into it.”

“You want to use my phone?—we can select some courses for you... what do they call that thing where they push the lion back with a kitchen chair?”

It was a warm sort of feeling that washed up from her stomach. It wasn’t the alcohol—but the port was quite excellent... While she laughed, she leaned to the side and bumped his shoulder with hers. It was a nice,

tender little thing that meant nothing. He was as pleasant as Cole and Maggie. Whatever happened, she felt she could be this guy's friend.

AROUND ELEVEN, Max was checking his watch.

She asked if he'd turn into a pumpkin. He just said it was getting late and then he was trying to catch Cole's eye.

Cole looked at the clock on the wall.

She got the picture. She said, "I should get going. I've got a lot to do tomorrow."

Maggie pursed her lips, like she didn't know what to do. Maybe wanted her to stay, maybe wanted her to go. She nodded, but then said, "Meet us for brunch tomorrow?"

"Oh, yeah?" she said. "I have a paper to write. Maybe. Text me."

She crossed over to give Maggie a hug. She'd talk to her tomorrow, try to find out what was bothering her. Maggie's eyes were wet again, and she wondered now if it wasn't a pregnancy but that she'd received bad news. Maggie took both her hands and squeezed them, stepped back. She looked to Max then sniffed. She said, "Can you take her back to her dorm?"

She looked over her shoulder and wished she didn't. There was a flash of disappointment on Max's face. He didn't want to take her to her dorm room.

Keely said, "Oh shit. No, don't do that. I'll call a cab."

Cole said, "No way. No fucking way. Max, give her a ride back."

She said, "Oh no, that's all right. I wouldn't want to trouble you—it's just a stroll through the neighborhood."

Max set down his empty port glass, said, "I'm taking you home."

She said, "No, I don't want that."

Maggie said, "Go," and pushed the small of Keely's back. Last thing she wanted to do right now was get back into Max's car. She felt very unwanted; a sudden third wheel even though there was four of them. She said, "No, don't make him. It's just five minutes away..."

Cole said, "You're not walking."

Max was jingling his keys in his pocket already, that coat shrugged on, and he said, "Come on. You're not walking, you're not taking a cab. I'll

take you, I'd be glad to."

She looked at all their faces. "If you're sure..."

THE CONVERSATION WAS STUNTED on the way back to Lowell. It was like Max knew he'd been caught making that funny face when asked to drive her and knew that he just fucked up. And she knew that he knew that—now it was hard to find things to talk about. They were awkward. He asked her about Harvard and if she liked living at Lowell. She gave the usual rigmarole and watched the storefronts as they passed.

Her phone dinged with a text and under normal circumstances she wouldn't answer but now it was an easy distraction. Pulled from her purse she saw it was from Derek, but opened it anyway.

Derek: howz ur date going?

"Huh," she scoffed and grumbled and Max looked over.

"Guy trouble?" he asked.

She scowled, looking straight ahead. Was this a setup or not? Why would Maggie and Cole bring them together and work all night at putting them on the same couch, in the same vehicle, side-by-side at dinner...? Though, no one told her it was a setup, maybe they hadn't told Max, either. The guy seemed smart—hadn't he figured it out?

"How'd you know?" she asked.

"I've been there. Made that exact noise many times myself." Then abruptly correcting an error: "I mean with girls, with girls, not with guys..."

"Don't worry," she joked, "your secret's safe with me."

He chuckled now, too, down shifting, saying, "Thanks, I appreciate it."

When they were around the corner, heading into the Square, he asked her: "This guy your boyfriend?"

"Ex," she told him. "Recently ex. Maggie never told you any of that?"

"No."

"Mm. Was her who told me the guy was out with other girls."

"What an idiot."

"You think so?"

He darted a quick look her way, then put eyes back on the road. “Of course. Why would he do that?”

“I know...”

“How long were you together?”

“Three months officially. Five altogether, but I was in Ireland over the summer.”

“That when Maggie saw...?”

“No. It was recent... But I figure it started when I was gone.”

“Probably...”

She growled and grimaced, rubbed her temples. “God, he gives me such a headache.”

“Want me to stop for aspirin?” Max said with wry humor, finger pointing up from the steering wheel as they approached a CVS.

Her mind flashed to her supplies in her toiletry kit—and she wasn’t joking about the headache...

“Would you mind really?” she said, leaning forward.

“What—really?”

“Yeah, I’m out of Advil and he’s giving me a literal headache...”

“Sure,” Max laughed now, slowing, waiting for a break in oncoming traffic before pulling a U-turn and parking out front of the pharmacy.

He stayed in the car when she went into the drugstore because she told him to. She went in, bought her pills, embarrassed now, paid the man at the counter, came back out. Max sat texting in the driver’s seat, chin tucked down, lips pouted, he looked good in his moody clothes and his black Porsche. But maybe he was too moody. There were guys like that. And the more moody they were, the more you fell for them, and things never ended well. It was an attractive thing to want to find out a mystery, but once you dug into its core, you got dirty up to your elbows.

She hopped in his car, closed the door behind her and put her purse between her feet.

Max said nothing, finished texting, put his phone in his pocket. He said, “You ready?” and she just nodded.

When Max turned the key to start the car again, nothing happened.

He twisted it again, and again nothing happened—just dead.

He sighed, “Oh shit.”

“Is it not working?”

She sounded so stupid. *Is it not working?* Does it sound like it's working? She worried about annoying him—guys were at their worst when they were tested.

But instead Max chuckled. He said, "I knew this was going to happen."

She said, "Looks like I'm walking home after all."

He said, "You're not going to stay with me?" He was looking at her, and the lights from the pharmacy twinkled in his eye. Those ruby lips were pulled to one side like he wanted to smile.

She said, "I've got a lot to do."

He said, "I need you here. Quick—tell me everything you know about batteries."

"We're in trouble," she said with a smile, "I don't know a thing."

HERE'S where she fell for him.

There were some seedy types hanging out smoking in front of the pharmacy, further from the doors and near the dark space between two businesses. They watched this guy with his stupid German sports car, back lid open, as he poked around at the motor. After he tried a few things, he got his phone out. Any guy she knew in a situation like this with a pretty redhead standing arms folded and watching as everything failed would call service. Call top-of-the-line service and make sure she saw him tip the guy a fifty. What does this guy Max do? Calls his dad. So here he was with his jacket off and the sleeves rolled up. Bent over with his head tucked in the back of his car. He was poking things, using her phone as a flashlight. She couldn't help but to come closer and watch him.

Max said to his father: "Which one? No, I don't see it Oh, okay So what do I do?..."

Now he reached in and she watched the muscles of his forearm move. He said, "Yeah, it's loose." His hand with her phone came back, and she took it, crouching with him and shining it where she thought he needed.

He said, "And that'll fix it?"

Now he laughed at something his father said. "You're such an idiot," he replied. She couldn't help reaching out and putting her hand on his back.

“Okay,” Max said, “yeah, I took it off No, I ran it across... Yeah, across some metal It was gummed up, I guess I got it hooked back on...”

He stood up, left the lid for the motor open, winked at her and mouthed hold on. He hopped in the driver seat, the brake lights flashed, then a click-click and the motor roared to life. She could see his silhouette in the driver seat from where she stood talking into his phone with his father. The sound of the motor had made the ruffians turn around but Max gave them a hardy thumbs up and they laughed. One of them put his cigarette in his mouth so he could clap with both hands. Now she slammed the lid down on the motor, trotted on her tiptoes and said Thank you, thank you to the applauding murderers and jumped in the seat, smiling toward them but not at them.

She said, “You’re quite the mechanic.”

He said, “It’s my dad. He’s a lawyer, too, but he fucking knows everything.”

She laughed and slapped his forearm where he held the steering wheel. She said, “Good—now let’s get out of here before one of those guys decides it might be fun to strangle us. More likely me...”

Max drove her to Lowell. He turned at the Lampoon, went along Holyoke and stopped. She said, “Well, thanks for everything. Thanks for the drive.”

He said, “It was nice to meet you. Now you’re a Max survivor.

“People have to survive you?”

“No, just the shit that happens around me.”

“Well that wasn’t too bad.”

“You were good about it.”

She looked in his eyes, said, “So were you.”

Now she saw his smile was steady, and she could feel a legitimate urge to ask him if he wanted to park and come up to her dorm room. Not that she would. But Max was warm and kind; she wanted to spend more time with him. She would love to hear more about his dad. She would love to hear more about the shit show he claimed his life was. *Who talked like that?* She was used to puffery over how someone had their shit *together*. Usually those people dragged you down to their reality without realizing it. While Max purported to be ensconced by bad fortune, she had the distinct feeling that was hyperbole and Max knew it, too. But there was a darkness,

regardless, and it was intriguing. There was something endearing in that cynical smile. It said he'd been through the wringer and survived. She said, "Well, give me your number. If I'm ever in New York City, I'll ring you."

With no reluctance, Max reached for his phone. He handed it to her, said, "You ever get to New York?"

"No," she laughed, "but let's stay in touch."

"You okay to get to your room?"

"Yeah, there're lights. I'm not gonna cut across the courtyard or anything, I just go up the stairwell." She nodded with her chin toward the bell tower.

He said, "Okay," taking his phone back. "Take care. It really was nice to meet you. I know I'll see you around."

"You will." She leaned to kiss him, but stopped herself before it was obvious. That was weird. She didn't even know why she did that. Now she turned the attempted kiss into an arm pat. It was awkward, and odd, and they both chuckled. She said, "See you around, Max," closed the door and went into Lowell.

Wooly Lamb

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 24

THE WOOLY LAMB Bagel Café was in the step-down of a Winthrop Street walk-up in Harvard Square. It was a short stroll from Lowell House and as she stepped down to the café's brick court, she could still see its bell tower rising above the roofline of the Malkin.

She was a little overdressed for a casual brunch but she looked like a girl who had a lot going on, wearing a skirt and tights and a Patagonia fleece pullover in a royal blue Batik Hex pattern that definitely set off the fire in her hair. Martina had peppered her with questions last night when she'd got in but she'd fended her off with non-committal *Oh, he was nice's*. But she'd probably given herself away with all the preening this morning, heading off to have brunch with this Max guy again.

It was warm but busy in the café, the small, sunken space loud with chatter and clatter; she found Cole, Maggie, and Max seated with coffees at a table for four. Maggie certainly looked brighter this morning; she practically glowed. The late-morning light from the window overhead put a white shine on her cheeks.

That happy face of hers went happier when she caught Keely making her way through the bustle. She actually stood, came around from behind the table where she was seated against the brick wall and hugged Keely tight.

Near her ear, she sighed, "I'm really so glad you came to join us."

"Girl's gotta eat," she said and pecked Maggie's cheek.

Max pushed out the chair meant for her and she shot him a dirty look, said, "Oh. You again."

He smiled, said, “Oh, great, the girl who ruins batteries—everyone check your watches, make sure they’re still working.”

Cole made a puzzled face, said, “Who wears a watch anymore?”

Max flashed him his wrist. He wore a black watch plaid button up with the sleeves rolled, jeans, and boots. On his wrist was some leather strap watch that looked old. Cole held Max’s wrist and lowered reading glasses out of his hair to examine Max’s watch while she hung her book bag and laptop on the corner post of her chair.

Maggie sat back down, said, “What’s this about batteries?”

They’d been kind and ordered her a cup of coffee. She added cream and said, “Your Max here likes old things that don’t work.”

Cole let Max’s wrist go, said, “Dude, you should hang out with my grandpa.”

“I just like things that are worn in.”

Cole sat back and gave a “Hey-oh,” smirking. Maggie side-glanced with disdain but her boyfriend didn’t notice.

It was quiet for a beat, and Keely said, “We had a little car trouble last night.”

Max shrugged. “Just a battery connection. Keely was very patient.” Maggie smiled, a funny wistful clouding in her eyes. Max added: “And a crucial component to getting us going again.”

“Aye, it’s true,” she said, “I held the flashlight.”

Maggie leaned forward, rubbing the backs of her arms. “Really? This happened on the way home last night?”

“Yeah, he didn’t tell you?”

Cole was looking at his menu, glasses on, eyebrows high. “We were in bed already.”

Max smiled and Maggie frowned at Cole who was oblivious again.

Max said, “I only relate tales of victory. My failures are best kept hidden.”

Keely lifted her menu, said, “Well, it wasn’t the highlight of the evening, but it was fun in its own way.”

Max put his hand on the post of her chair and got close to her, eyes turned down to the book bag and laptop bag. He said, “You take brunch seriously. What’s in there, special cutlery?”

“I’ve got my books with me.”

Maggie said, “We’re lucky to have her here, she’s got work to do.”

Keely said, “Yeah, I’ve got a date with the library after brunch, and if all goes well, I won’t be home till very late.”

“And walking funny,” Cole said into his menu. Max pressed his fingertips against either side of his nose, eyes wide; groaning in disbelief that his friend said that. Maggie winced and sighed, “Oh, my God.”

Keely leaned forward and let them hear her laugh—she was hard to offend. She said, “Someone’s certainly feeling more comfortable around me these days.”

Cole rolled his eyes, his head lolled on his shoulders and he met Maggie’s gaze. They communicated something, saying nothing, blinking. It was a funny composition; the way Cole slouched, head fallen back, him sitting underneath Maggie who was upright and leaning over him. It was sweet to see such a stud bull like Cole tamed by love.

Cole gently tapped Maggie’s forehead with his menu and she smiled and closed her eyes in preparation. He said, “Come on, it was funny. It’s a big library.”

Maggie was still smiling when she took his menu away from him, said, “I’ll apologize for him. But it’s really Max’s fault—these two get together, you never know what’s going to happen.”

Cole still regarded her while she talked, head leaned back drowsily. He said, “Well, you kinda know what’s going to happen.”

Max chuckled and hid his face in the menu, and Maggie shook her head in a slow admonishment. Cole leaned for a kiss, and she stroked his neck while they did. When Cole broke away he changed the subject: “Keely—what are you working on, a paper? You studying?”

“A paper,” she said.

“GOV?”

“Uh-huh.”

He tapped Max’s arm, saying, “You should go help her.” Maggie’s hand squeezed nails into Cole’s arm.

Max scoffed. “She probably wants to get a good grade, though.”

“I don’t need any help,” she sang.

Max said to Cole: “You graduated GOV with me.”

Cole said, “I help her, she’ll be on academic suspension.”

The waiter was there finally, harassed due to the crowd but maintaining pleasantries. Everyone ordered; she wanted turkey and avocado on a

pumpnickel bagel, also ordered a Caribbean Café con Leche looking for a caffeine buzz to fuel her afternoon in the library.

When the waiter was gone, Cole said to Keely, “Seriously, Max was summa, 4.0. You guys should exchange phone numbers.”

Max said, “I don’t know if she needs any help, or if I would be any help, but she already has my number.” He’d leaned an elbow on the table, his cheek in the cup of his palm. He smiled; the light lit up his eyes and there was a glowing warmth from him. Max was night and day; the capricious, sensitive bad boy and she could feel a glimmer of interest in both sides of his coin.

She nodded, smiled too, said, “We exchanged numbers last night.”

Maggie’s voice was quiet: “You did?”

And while she was watching Max, she could see in her periphery Maggie’s bright smile fade to dim.

Adios

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 25

HER PAPER on the U.S. recognition of Liberian independence in 1862 was finished at nine-thirty at night. She left the library and finished some reading in the common room at Lowell. At eleven she mounted the steps on woozy legs, slipped into the dorm room without waking Martina and collapsed into bed, pulling her blanket over top of her, still wearing her clothes.

It had been a great day of focus and accomplishment. A little glimmer flickered on her back burner—but it somehow helped her steady her concentration on the tasks at hand. It was an exciting little thing that she could contemplate later, and she enjoyed having things to look forward to.

Now she was laying in bed looking at the ceiling, lights from the street running sideways parallelograms. She was smiling in the dark.

Max was a proposition. There was something there.

Sleep was evading her despite how tired she was, so she drew out her phone and hid it with her under the light blanket. She texted Marly.

Keely: wakey wakey

She held the phone to her chest face down, looking up with a thin blanket draped over her face. It was a few minutes, but Marly got back to her.

Marly: its 530 in the morning

Shit. Marly was in Munich for a month staying with some of their friends from the old days at The Bray Academy. She knew the time difference but did it quick in her head and was off by an hour. Knew it was early, but not that early. Marly was not an easy riser. She sent a gif of a kitten in a basket making a pleading motion with its two paws and a rainbow overtop had the words 'sorry' written in it.

Marly: I was in the loo so ur lucky

Marly: whats up?

Keely: boy stuff

Marly: wide awake rn

Keely: lol good. Met someone

Marly: done with Derek?

Keely: think so

Marly: whos the guy?

Keely: Max Milton

Marly: on facebook?

Keely: yes

It was a minute before she texted in return.

Marly: cute. Is he tall?

Keely: not short. Good job. Older

Marly: hot

Keely: he's special

Marly: I'm listening...

Keely: Friend of a friend, a setup

Marly: You going out with him?

Keely: Group only but I want to

Marly: What's he do?

Keely: Finance

Marly: Yuck

Keely: He's not like that tho I swear

Marly: ok

Keely: I have a crazy good feeling about him

Marly: You've had crazy good feelings before

Keely: he's a nice guy

Marly: good. Yawn. boring

Keely: I know but maybe not so nice too

Marly: so what's the problem?

She chuckled under the blanket.

Keely: I just wanted to talk about him

Marly: aw Keely has real feelings

Now Marly sent an image of a woman in a Victorian dress, maybe from an old color cowboy movie, spinning and swooning with her hands gathered over her chest. She laughed, texted:

Keely: not quite. Just curious

Marly: I say go for it

Keely: you think so?

Marly: you know ur going to

Keely: yes

Marly: can I go back to bed now?

Keely: stay up with me and we'll chat

Marly: no!

Keely: cunt

Marly: lol slut

Keely: hows munich?

Marly: byyyyyeeee

Keely: thnx for talking go to sleep

Marly sent a gif of a cartoon woman's lips smacking a kiss. She shut her phone down and looked up at the ceiling, seeing only blanket, feeling her lashes tickle against it as she blinked.

Phone brought up again, she texted:

Keely: where ar u?

Derek: Bozemans. Want to talk now?

There was no way she would go to Bozeman's Bar this late, paying for a cab to the city, and she had class in the morning. Only thing was this was something she wanted done, and it wouldn't be done on the phone nor by text. Derek agreed to come her way and they would meet at The Burger Company, a late night joint on Massachusetts Avenue just a few minutes away. It wasn't a bar, it was bright, and there were likely people she might know from school.

SHE ARRIVED FIRST, took a table for two against the wall under a five-foot tall black and white drawing of James Joyce. She ordered a shot of Jameson's for courage and a separate Diet Coke. The whisky was delivered and drank before Derek arrived about ten minutes later.

The restaurant was a late night haunt for many students, but the place closed in about fifteen minutes so it was sparsely populated, and those lingering at tables had that hunched-over pose of the young and drunk, eating burgers and/or colorfully decorated sundaes with half-lidded eyes. Derek sauntered in, giving that familiar look of disdain around him. He admired she was at Harvard, but he was bypassing college and making money without it, hustling three jobs: personal trainer, carpenter, and what he called 'entrepreneurship' (a host of online promotional businesses that showed some success). Tall and darkly handsome, he exuded menace. Once he spied her, he made his way to the table without an improvement in his

expression and plopped down across from her, his weight making the metal feet of the chair give a brief screech against the tile.

"I'm here," he said, crossing his arms, big hands gripping the biceps under his leather jacket, "and if this is my brush off, you're making a big fucking mistake, Keely."

"I'm sorry, Derek," she said, her hands cupping the cool pebbled plastic of her Diet Coke. "You know I can't do this anymore. I told you."

"So this is it?"

"We both need to move on," she said, not looking up.

"This is ridiculous," he muttered and in her periphery she was aware of him shaking his head. "Whoever your fucking spy is she's lying."

Now she was shaking her head. "How do you know it's a she?"

"Is it a guy? Probably that Chinese girl..."

"It doesn't matter, Derek. You know how I feel about that, about faithfulness. I told you how I feel, how it hurts."

"Come on, Keely. I'm not cheating on you."

"Were you out with another girl?"

"What did this friend of yours see?"

"Said you were out in public with a girl, and you looked what they said was very familiar."

"What did the girl look like?"

"The one you were with? Why, were there more than one and you want to narrow down your possible explanations?"

"Why did I ever get involved with a girl who wants to be a fucking lawyer?" he groaned and rubbed his face with his hands, then leaning his elbows on the table.

She said, "You're a glutton for punishment."

"I'm not, Keely. I'm the fucking man and you know I am."

"Do I?"

"Come on. I told you, I'm not cheating on you."

"But you were out in public with multiple girls in a somewhat familiar fashion, enough so that you're afraid to admit to the wrong girl and I'll know there was more than one."

"I'd be crazy to cheat on you, Keely. Look at you."

"Who might my friend have seen you with?"

"Keely..."

“Take the risk, Derek, admit to one and let’s see where this line of questioning takes us.”

He groaned a sound of exasperation, hugged his elbows and leaned closer. His jaw muscles flexed. Stubble darkened his cheeks and neck and his eyes twinkled black. His mouth worked around and his brow lowered. “Three days before you went to Ireland I went out for a drink after work with a girl from the gym.”

“Ireland over the summer, or Ireland last week?”

“Last week.”

“How was her head?”

“You gotta be kidding me. Don’t say that.”

“Well? You’re both a fan of drinks... Alcohol, too, I’m guessin.’ Tell me, then, if I went out for some drinks, one-on-one, with some good-looking guy after class sometime and you saw, you’d be all right with that?”

“Are you cheating on me with him?”

“Oh, look at you pretending to be noble. You’re a good actor. Only I know yeh, and I know you’d cause a scene, even if we just wanted to quench our thirst, innocent like.”

“Didn’t you fuck two guys in Ireland?”

“Aye, I did, two guys I fucked a lot in private school, and I sure missed their big cocks, I—”

He slapped his hand down hard on her, clamping her wrist. The Diet Coke bounced and wobbled and the ice clinked. She wanted to cry out, the pain and shock jumped out at her, but she swallowed it and instead clenched her jaw. Through gritted teeth she said, “Get yer fuckin’ hand off me.”

“You’re a big mouth,” he said, grinning in her face with a malevolent meanness she’d always known was there; in fact its simmering bubbles were probably what drew her to him in the first place.

“David, it’s a big mistake if you don’t let me go.”

“Who’s David?” His grip tightened.

“Aye, sorry,” she said, not missing a beat, “he’s the last one that grabbed me like this and sometimes he’s my Yorick.”

“What?”

She looked up to the chalkboard ceiling and the artful scribblings scrawled across it. With faint drama, she said, “I knew him, Horatio; a fellow of infinite jest, of most excellent fancy; he hath borne me on his back a thousand times; and now, how abhorred in my imagination it is...”

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

“If you don’t let go of my wrist, you dumb fuck, I’ll be walking around delivering soliloquies to your boiled skull.”

“You’re such a cunt.”

“I am. You think you’re the first to notice? You want me to slink back to me dorm and go Boo-hoo, oh no, I’m a cunt? You’re the fella I always thought you were. You proved it to me. No big deal. Now hitch up your pants and get on the road, aye? There’s plenty of Keelys and plenty of Dereks in the world, we don’t have to be each other’s.”

With his grip still steely tight on her wrist, shooting a pain up to her elbow, he watched her with subdued hate; handsome and male, but shitty and ugly now, he breathed through his nose and showed her with his eyes all the ways he wanted to hate-fuck her out back in the alley. She showed him no fear though it twinkled somewhere in her darkness.

He let the hold go, gathered his two strong hands under his chin and regarded her, every bit of him struggling for finger-hold on his masculinity and squeezing it for strength. “Your friend’s a fucking liar because I swear to you I was faithful.”

She gathered her wrist and soothed it.

“I’m sorry, Keely,” he said, looking at her hands. “I don’t like being called a liar. When I’m innocent, I want to defend myself.”

She was sullen a moment, thumb rubbing the wrist bone, her lips tightened to a narrow point. “I didn’t cheat on you in Ireland.”

“Don’t tell me you did then.”

“I’m mad too.”

“I get that. Look, you told me about your dad that time and I heard you, I’m not such a fucking jerk like you think. It’s just,” he made a growling sound and looked up. “If you’re dumping me, I just...”

“What?” she said, a little meanly, “wished you had fucked a dozen girls when I was away...”

Derek did a funny dismissive laugh but didn’t deny it. It was a pebble on the scale in favor of him; an honest but despicable notion that inclined her closer to believing he was faithful. It also reinforced her decision to end it, as much fun as he had been.

She sighed, “Maybe you didn’t...”

“I didn’t, Keely,” he said earnestly, looking like he wanted to reach out and grip her again but held back.

“Derek,” she sighed heavier this time, “I just, I have so much going on and I don’t like how this happened...”

“Nothing happened.”

“Maybe, but, I just, I think it’s really over.” It took effort, but she looked up to meet his gaze. He was looking away, jabbing a thumb into his mouth and biting the nail.

He said, “This is such fucking bullshit, Keely. How was your date? Or was that a lie too?”

“No, that was real. But I don’t even think it was a date.”

“It’s not some other guy?”

She shook her head no because it wasn’t his business—and besides, she wasn’t sure this was all because of Max.

“Whatever,” he muttered. Then before hefting himself out of the chair, added: “Your fucking loss.”

Elbows on the table, she hung her head against her wrists and watched him leave. Despite the bad that came with him, that was five months of her life walking out in tight black jeans, three months spent together. Derek was fun; dominant in good ways sometimes, not so great in others. The fact that he would cheat on her wasn’t a crazy one. He was the type; admitted it to her he’d cheated on girls before, one time in bed together when they were talking post-coitus. Didn’t even realize the incrimination of his statement, almost as if he assumed she was also some kind of player who must have cheated on boyfriends.

Derek tried to close the door hard behind him but it was on hydraulics. Instead of banging it stopped short with a hiss, but there was a chime made of dangling tin hamburger profiles and they banged and jangled and clattered against the glass. It made her wince. But she also smirked with resignation; that was the kind of guy he was.

A girl who must have been first year at MIT (given the sweatshirt and the fresh face) scooted over from a table of seven near the middle of the floor, crouching. Her afro was pulled back from her face and tied in a pom-pom at the back of her head. She could see her wan reflection in the girl’s glasses.

“You okay?” the girl asked.

“I’m fine,” she said.

The girl put a tentative hand on her back and it was welcome. “Do you want to walk back with us?”

“I’m okay,” she said. “His bark’s worse than his bite.”

“I like your accent.” The girl smiled.

“Thank you,” she said. “I’m going to get an Uber.”

“You want to come sit with us?”

She nodded slowly. “Yeah, I do...”

Stacks

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 27

KEELY TEXTED.

Keely: fucking where? I'm so lost

Maggie got back to her.

Maggie: Ha ha level D, it's written above

Keely: I thought I was on D. Now I AM on D 😁

She was forty feet underground, descending below the Widener Library, deep in the stacks and a little freaked out.

Keely: yes, I'm on D for sure now, bottom of the stairs

Maggie: which stairs?

Keely: OMG what rack are you at?

Maggie: JM 6767

Keely: stay there. I'm freaking out down here

Maggie: what if I jump out at you?

Keely: I'll black your eye 🙄

To conserve electricity, the stacks were kept in the dark, and lights came on only with motion detectors. There was no one else down here now and the subterranean chamber was silent like a tomb. Every sharp noise she made—the scrape of her loafers—made an echo that sounded like skittering insects.

With her book bag clutched to her chest she strode as quiet as she could down the narrow path, alleys of metal rack bookshelves extending in lines to her right. Lights shone down in silent cones ahead of her, clicking on as they anticipated her arrival. Ahead she could see a bookshelf row already lit—it had to be Maggie down there. She put aside the notion of some burgeoning campus strangler laying in wait with Maggie's phone, luring this complacent Irish girl closer, Maggie's prostate body at his feet.

About six feet back she read the row's placard proclaiming JM 6767. And from the alley of books, Maggie's light voice: "Down here."

Now she was quick-step shuffling, closing the distance between the two girls and as soon she saw her friend, she felt better instantly. Not that the two girls could together fend off some sort of machete-wielding murderer. She clutched her book bag tighter.

She said, "How can you be down here alone like this?"

Maggie said, "It's fine."

"You don't get freaked out?"

Maggie made an uneasy expression. She admitted: "I'm glad you're here."

"What are you doing?"

Maggie said, "Down in the stacks? Shopping for shoes...?" She chuckled, turned her back to Keely now and was reaching up to a shelf that was three from the top, pulling a fat, leather-bound book down.

"Ha, ha. You know what I mean."

"Research," Maggie said, "And what are you doing down here?"

"I need to talk to you."

"What is it?" Maggie said, turning her back against the books lined along the shelf and eyeing Keely earnestly.

Keely said, "I got myself in a bit of a jam."

"What did you do?"

"I went to High Table, thanks again."

"No problem."

"Yeah, so I go, everything was great... We eat dinner, they serve drinks. I'm not going to lie, I had a few. Next thing I know, I'm talking to the governor."

"Sounds good so far."

"Tell me about it. So I'm talking to the governor, and he introduces me to an executive woman works for the mayor."

"What city?"

"New York City."

"That's pretty great..."

"I know... So I'm talking with this woman and she's telling me I'm 'everything they're looking for' down at the office." She used finger quotes for emphasis.

"You probably are."

"Well, that's what I'm thinking, but I'd had a few." She rubbed her forehead, paused to listen because she swore she heard a shoe shuffling somewhere in the dark. She continued: "I'm feeling flattered. So now we're talking and she's telling me about the internship program."

"Internship under the mayor?"

"Yeah, that's right. She's telling me about this internship program, and I'm feeling really good. And I start blasting back and forth with her about all my opinions..."

"You've got a lot of them."

"I do. I'm telling her about them, but she doesn't think they're stupid. She thinks they're pretty good ideas."

"That's great."

"Yeah, and I'm feeling good about it, too, because I do think it's great—like a compliment. So she tells me that she could get me on the internship program. I tell her that's incredible."

"That is pretty incredible."

"Right? I'm telling her I'm interested, and we're talking back and forth like this is a thing that's going to happen."

"Did she offer you an internship?"

“Close. Here’s the thing: whatever she offers me I have to move to New York City. I have no intention of ever moving to New York City. But she offered an invitation to an event and I know I have to go...”

“Yeah, so...?”

Even though Maggie was asking for more information, she could feel a certain tension between them now all of a sudden, Maggie hugged the book she pulled from the shelf against her chest, smart enough to see one step ahead.

She said, “It’s a function. The invitation’s to a dinner. Invitations, plural, for two—I was wondering...”

Maggie slumped against the shelf, her brow lowered, listening intently.

Keely said, “They’re going to give me a tour of the mayor’s office during the day, and I’ll meet with the current interns. That evening there’s the dinner—it’s like a party. At least I get to wear my High Table dress again.”

“It sounds great...”

Keely braced herself, but couldn’t help a certain tightening of her expression. She squinted her eyes, but kept contact with Maggie. She said, “What if I ask your friend Max to come with me? It’s in Manhattan, he’s in Manhattan. What would you think of that?”

Maggie slumped further, sliding down one of the central braces of the bookshelf. Her eyebrows raised up and her mouth opened but she said nothing.

She said “Is it weird? Do you know what I mean? Because he’s your friend?”

Maggie let out a croaky *No*.

“You don’t think it’s weird?”

“No, I don’t.”

“You’re sure?”

Maggie slumped further, and now both of them were sinking to sit on the floor. Maggie’s back slid down the metal brace, and she settled on the floor with a hard thump. Keely sat cross-legged next to her, their knees touching.

She said, “I don’t even know I was talking about with that woman. I think I’m terrible at schmoozing. That’s a thing, right? There could be a person like me who’s not good at schmoozing. I was there to schmooze, and

all of a sudden I'm just gushing over people and offering things, and I'm acting like I want this internship."

Maggie's voice was quiet. "You don't want it?"

"I have to live in New York City, Maggie. I start JD next year."

"You didn't tell her that?"

"I thought it was implied... Where else would I be going to law school if I'm at High Table...?"

They were quiet a long while and stared at the book spines across from them. She said, "I thought maybe you were setting me up with Max."

"You did?"

"You know... going out the other night..."

"Oh. I wanted you two to meet. I thought for sure you would like each other. You're kind of just like him."

"But not like this?..."

Maggie sighed softly, clutched the book tighter, but shook her head no. "No, Keely, I swear this is fine."

"Just fine?"

Maggie chuckled softly.

She said, "Max seems really nice. Really interesting. I wouldn't mind getting to know him."

Maggie nodded and Keely watched as her chin dimpled and her face pinched into a sad scowl. A wet seam appeared in her eyelashes and Keely asked her what was wrong, leaning close so their faces were near and their shoulders touched.

"Nothing, nothing's wrong. Nothing is wrong. It's a great idea."

"Why do you keep doing this—crying? What's going on with this Max?"

"Nothing's going on with him."

"Just tell me what's going on, please..."

"He's a great guy. You couldn't get a better guy."

The way Maggie scrunched her face, a tear squeezed at the corner of her eye and rolled down toward her ear and it made her upset. She wasn't that intimate with Maggie but she was reaching out for her now, holding her shoulder. "What's wrong? This is ridiculous..." Then it occurred to her.

"Go to the party with him..."

Keely asked: "Did you have a thing with Max?"

“Did I have a thing with Max?” Maggie’s voice was tight and on the verge of tears.

“You had a thing with him, didn’t you?”

Maggie nodded. “I had a thing with him.”

Two good but simultaneous questions: “Was he good to you? Do you still have feelings for him?”

Maggie shook her head no vehemently. “No, no, it’s not that...”

“What is it then?”

“I had a *thing* with him.”

“It was *serious*?”

Maggie chuckled, leaned her head forward and rubbed her eyes with her knuckles. She laughed a bit more, said, “Oh, yeah. We were pretty serious.”

“Should I not go with him? I *won’t* go with him...”

Maggie started. “No, you *have* to go with him. It’s not that...”

“What is it?”

Maggie had to wipe her eyes again. She wore an untucked flannel shirt over khaki shorts. She brought up one of the loose tail ends and wiped her cheeks. She said, “We had a thing...” then sighed, “I have to be honest. We were engaged.”

Keely reeled. She dipped her head, pressed the point of her middle finger between her eyes to keep her focus. “You were engaged to Max?”

Maggie nodded and her face scrunched up again like she would cry.

“When was this?”

“At Farmingham,” she said then covered her face with her hands.

She rubbed Maggie’s back, squeezed the nape of her neck.

“We were engaged at Farmingham. And I loved him. I loved him so much. I thought we’d be together forever. I was sure of it. I wanted to be with him forever.”

“What happened?”

Maggie rubbed her eyes, digging the heels of both hands into her eye sockets. She shrugged.

“I won’t go with him.”

Maggie shook her head vigorously. “No, you have to go. It’s not like that.”

“What is it?”

“You’re not ever going to find a better guy than Max. I swear to God. I swear on my heart, Keely. There’s not a better guy out there.”

“What happened? You broke up with him?”

Maggie nodded, then turned away so Keely wouldn't see her.

It broke her heart, and though they weren't intimate friends, she felt a sudden and deep connection with this girl. She got closer, shifted her hips until they were touching. She said, “Is it okay if I hold you?”

Maggie nodded.

She put her arms around her, one hand gripping her shoulder, the other coming down and touching her elbow. Maggie fell against her, but instead of crying she was laughing. She said, “I can't believe I'm crying like this.”

“Maggie, I'm serious. I won't go with him if you don't want.”

“It's not that at all, Keely. It's not that at all...”

“I don't want to see you cry. I've never seen you cry...”

“I'm not crying. Not crying for sadness.” Now she looked up, her expression a little brighter though her eyes looked puffy. “I can't believe I'm over sharing like this.”

“I want you to,” she said. “This is great. I never knew this.”

Maggie said, “Sorry for the...” and wiggled her fingers at her own face indicating the tears. “I didn't see it coming like that. Max and I were a long time ago. But yeah, you have to go out with him. You two are perfect.” Now she was fumbling, shoulder rising up as she put her hand in her shorts pocket and brought out her phone, swiped the screen and touched her passcode, then was dialing. She sniffled, pinched the bridge of her nose to extinguish sounds of sadness.

Keely said, “What are you doing?”

“I'm showing you.”

“Showing me what?” She could hear the sound of a male voice answering Maggie's call.

Maggie said into the phone: “Maxy, how are you doing?”

Keely gripped Maggie's forearm with both her hands and held her tight, scowling, but trying to hear what he said.

“Uh-huh,” Maggie said, “so your friend Keely has an event with the Mayor's office, guess where...” she made a soft giggle, “you're so silly, I can't believe you're what? no, you are Manhattan that's right I don't know, she'll tell you escort her for me text her or she'll text you you're the best No, I have to run, I'll call you later...” Now she smiled wide. “I love you, too... Bye, Maxy.” She hung up, smiling still, put her phone back in her pocket.

“That was more for you, wasn’t it?” she whispered, swiping away a tear along Maggie’s jawline with the back of her index finger.

Maggie sighed a contented sound, said, “It was for you, too. You’ll have fun with Max.”

“Thank you,” she said.

Maggie’s brow dropped a measure and her expression went serious again. “Don’t mention to Max, you know, *anything*. Don’t say you know we were engaged and don’t, you know... He doesn’t like to talk about it, I don’t like to either, as you can see.” Now she laughed a little and looked at her balled hands in her lap, holding the book against her stomach. “Don’t say that we talked like this either, please...?”

“No, I know, I won’t. Mum’s the word.”

Mayor

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 31

SHE SAID, “You’ve known them a long time, yeah?”

Max was walking with his hands behind his back looking down at the gravel path. He said, “A long time. Cole was my roommate first year at Farmingham. I met Maggie at a Kappa party I think October of my first year.”

“They’re good friends.”

“The best friends,” he said.

“Aye,” she said, and couldn’t help putting her own hands behind her back and mimicking his walk now.

They were in a children’s park on the lower East Side, walking along Houston but heading toward a fence-lined path leading into a maze of red-brick walkups zig-zagged with fire escapes. She was wearing her High Table dress under a down jacket; Max a gray flannel suit with an unbuttoned dress shirt. She’d taken the train from Boston this morning, checked into her hotel in Korea Town, then took a cab to the intern’s office over at the United Nations Plaza. The executive, Kacey, gave her a tour and then she spent an hour with the interns and asked questions. All they wanted to talk about was the party. At five she took a cab back to her hotel to change, then rode the subway to Astor Place Station. Max had met her at the street level, standing by a rack of bikes. She emerged from the station under a green-patina Victorian kiosk and he was waiting, smiling. They hugged.

It was a short walk together down Bowery to the party which was at a piano lounge filled with old pianos, some of them for sale. He’d been an

excellent companion for her event with the mayor's office. He was calm and capable, but subdued. He wasn't out there trying to show off for her, showing her what a big-shot he was. He let her shine, standing behind her, letting her lead the way. And he was handsome. Really handsome in his suit. Maybe he wasn't six-two like a certain fucking asshole named Derek, but he had style and he was charming. And there was something cynically confident in his eyes that she couldn't stop thinking about.

She swore she wasn't going to, but ended up having three whiskey Collins during the evening. She'd nursed them, spread them out, and right now was feeling pretty great. Kacey, the executive she met at High Table, hadn't wanted her for the internship program after all, at least not right away. But she made friends there, and who knows where it could go in the future. The woman knew she was going to the JD program next year. Also somehow in the meantime had discovered that her father was a diplomat. As they departed, Kacey made her swear to keep in touch, offering her personal phone contact.

Now she and Max were crossing a street called Suffolk, getting to the far sidewalk and entering a narrow green-space between two brick buildings. It was 11 P.M. on a Saturday night, Halloween, and still early. The trees were strung with lights, the stone walkway lit with globe lanterns. Four girls in black leotards with skeletons painted on passed by, one of them handed her a candy necklace (which she would never eat).

Max's apartment wasn't far from the piano lounge, just around the corner, and she'd asked him to escort her for a fresh air stroll before she called herself a cab to take her to the hotel. She could see he was a gentleman, could see him trying to formulate ways to invite her to stay if she wanted without it sounding like some sort of trap. In the end he didn't offer. But now they were on his street and he was pointing out the building where he lived.

"See, that one up there." A low-rise, maybe eight or nine stories, black steel and red brick.

"Yeah, I see it. You lived there long?"

"Just eight months now."

"Is it vintage? You know, worn in?"

He chuckled. "I don't think it is."

While he was a great companion for the party, they hadn't spent a lot of time getting to know each other—and she wanted to know more about him.

So when he offered for her to come up to his place and wait for a cab, she said, "Would you make me a drink?"

He said Sure.

Now they were walking through his lobby, Max flashing his card at the console, and the door buzzing. He held it open, and she caught a glimpse of their reflection in a mirror against the wall. Two well-dressed young people, looking quite good together. Brooding Max with his dark hair and knowing eyes, and a smart redhead who should have worn a better jacket with her fancy dress.

On the elevator ride up, she said, "Have you had any more problems your dad had to fix?"

She saw his smile reflected in the gold-paneled control box of the elevator car. He said, "Since the battery incident? No, I've been problem free for a while now."

Walking the hallway to his apartment, she said, "What about your mother? What's she like?"

He sighed, raised his eyebrows as he considered what he would say. He said, "She's always been a mom. Housewife to my dad. She raised me, my brothers, and my sister."

"Big family?"

"I have a brother Connor, another one Michael. I have a sister Frances, too. They're all out of the house now, it's just my folks alone."

"Where's that?" They'd stopped at a glossy black apartment door.

"Michigan," he said, and opened it to let her into the unit.

It was about what she expected. Not flashy, not ostentatious in any way. A typical single guy's apartment on the cheap. A couch along one wall, a TV on the other, a leather chair that looked quite comfortable. A surprising number of plants. A phonograph, which figured, sitting on a low two-shelf unit, records lining both its shelves. The view out his window was an old Georgian building on Houston with a British pub in its corner, a Sheffield Arms, bustling, doors open and the sound of a live band from inside.

She told him. "It's sparse."

And he told her: "I'm always at work."

"No lady friends calling?"

"No," he laughed. "Too busy."

She slipped her heels off, stepped inside and flung her jacket on the couch, picked up a ceramic raven from a shelf of books and examined it.

She said, "But you get to Boston a good amount."

"As much as I can," he said, put his hands in his pockets and leaned against the wall. "Can I get you a drink?"

"What do you have?"

THEY WERE on the couch now, sitting at distant ends, and she wondered why he'd chosen the far arm when she would've permitted much closer. She took a sip of the Jameson's he'd poured her. He held his in his lap. She said, "I should call that cab."

He nodded. He said, "What about *your* family?"

"Mine?" she said. "In Ireland. Most of them. I've got two sisters and a brother, I guess that's the converse of you."

"Spooky," he said and took a sip of his whiskey.

"I was just in Ireland two weeks ago. It was my grandma's eightieth birthday, and she flew me in."

"Where in Ireland?"

"Aughrim."

"Where's that?"

She waved him off. "In Ireland. East a way from Galway Bay. The country."

"You grew up there?"

"I did. There and Qatar. Some other places. My father is a diplomat..."

"Well, well, well," Max said and raised one eyebrow.

"Yeah, but only to Qatar."

Max laughed, and she scrunched up her nose; her father's position in Saudi Arabia was as complicated as he was. "It's not really official, but he works out of the Irish embassy in Dubai." She took another sip, said, "My mom is back in Aughrim with her family."

"Are they divorced?"

She shook her head no. She winced a little and contemplated, then told him: "She's got cancer. She's in Ireland for the healthcare."

Max leaned forward and set his glass on the low coffee table. He said, "Sorry. She's okay?"

“She is. Now she is. She went through it, but she’s in remission. Breast cancer. But I just saw her at the party, she couldn’t be happier in her red wig.”

“That’s good to hear.”

It was quite a moment, and she regretted bringing the party down.

Max cleared his throat, said, “My mother’s going through it too. She has Hodgkins. Year and a half now, and she’s in remission as well.”

“Oh, Max, I’m sorry. Look at me—I really know how to get us both going.”

He gave a light laugh and touched his cheek, and she knew that he was trying not to shed a tear. And that got her going now, and she had to put knuckles under both her eyes. “It’s hard, isn’t it?” she said.

“It sure isn’t easy,” Max said. “I always thought it was going to be so much easier.”

“Life, you mean?”

“Yeah, life. I thought things would just fall into place better.”

“There’s always somebody trying to take it from you,” she said.

“Isn’t that the truth,” he said.

SHE DIDN’T CALL for a cab. In fact, she let Max pour them another drink. Now she was looking at her phone saying, “Holy shit, Max. It’s one o’clock...”

He said, “You can stay here. You don’t have to call a cab, it’s late now, anyway.”

She said, “I’m not putting you out?”

“No, not at all. I think you should stay.”

“I left my change of clothes at the hotel.”

“I’ll take you there in the morning.”

“Okay,” she said. Then when it was quiet for another moment again, she said, “I’m not ready for bed yet.”

“Me neither.”

Bad Turn

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 1

TWO IN THE morning and they were still up laughing. She said, “Go on and get out of here.”

“No, I’m serious.”

“I can’t even picture it,” she said and drained her glass.

“I have pictures, but I can tell you she would fucking-A stuh-rangle me if I showed you.”

“Blue hair?”

“Blue hair, and like platinum streaks.”

She broke out laughing again. “Did she really? You’re not putting me on? Send me a picture when you’re brave enough.”

“Don’t even tell her I told you,” he laughed, then nudging her elbow with the back of his hand he said, “She was in the art program.”

“Go on and stop it...”

“She was. She’s an incredible artist.”

“Yeah, I thought she might.”

“You thought she might do art?”

“No, I mean whatever she would do, she would do it well, I thought.”

“Yes,” Max agreed and looked down again, swirling his remaining whiskey.

She asked, “What kind of art?—oh wait, I know she plays the cello. Cole said that...”

Max said, “And paints. Paints and draws. She’s really amazing, I mean it.”

“How did she get into law?”

Max shrugged, drained his glass now. The humor was gone. He said, "Her mother's a lawyer."

"Oh, that's right. I knew that. And Cole, too."

"Right."

Now she gave him a pouting face. "Aw, Max lost his two best friends to Harvard."

He didn't smile. She winced. She said, "It sucks when your friends leave you, doesn't it?"

"It does," he said, then he smiled...

"What?..."

"You know she never shaved her armpits either..."

IT WAS 2:30 in the morning when she closed the remaining space between them on the couch and kissed him. Max saw it coming and looked like he wanted to run out of the room. Only he didn't. He was frozen; watching her get closer, knowing what she was going to do. She'd have liked to see him move toward her, but it wasn't the first time she'd had to take the lead. Max's lips parted to accept hers. They were soft and plump and cool from the whiskey. The Lovin' Spoonful spun on the record player, an album cover with a naked man and woman running in the woods alongside a lion; very fitting. She was on her knees on the couch seat; she put her hand on his chest, let it slide up to hold his neck and run her fingernails against his ear while she kissed him. She let their mouths part, withdrew to look in his eyes. He was horrified, bewildered. When his eyes turned down to watch her mouth, she smiled and bit her lip. He was powerless. She moved in and kissed him again...

THEY MADE out on his couch in the quiet; the needle retracted from the vinyl and the arm rested in its cradle. The speakers let out a faint crackling hiss. Her hand worked down his body. His hands were tentative. They kissed for a while before he even rested them on her waist. They were there

now, and he was feeling how trim she was. It was a good thing it was the beginning of the school year.

Her nipples ached, scratching against the spandex bra's confines. She felt them throbbing with need, wanting to feel Max's hands on her. It hadn't been that long she'd been without, only two weeks, but Max felt *good*. If he wasn't going to touch her, she would touch him. Now she grabbed him between his legs, very pleased to find him hard as steel. He sighed the pepper of whiskey into her mouth at the feel of her hand against his erection.

She got her mouth very near his ear and whispered, "My mother told me boys will try to come in my mouth and not even tell me. You won't do that to me, willya?"

Max shook his head no and his body trembled. She swallowed her smile.

She asked him, "Can I trust you?"

"You can."

"I'm not supposed to put your thing in my mouth without a condom on it, but I have a good feeling about you."

"You should."

"I should what? Trust you or put your thing in me mouth?"

"Oh, fuck," he groaned and squinted his eyes. "Both."

Now she smiled.

"If you come in my virgin mouth, Max Milton, I swear I'll spit it down the neck of your nice shirt." The tips of her fingers plucked at his shirt collar and she bit his earlobe. He jolted. His cock was like a steel bar in her grip. She had a foul mouth and a dirty mind, and there wasn't a sober man who'd stayed soft on her.

She bit his neck while she undid his zipper. He squirmed underneath her, his hands pushing against her as if to stop her, but she wasn't going to stop. She brought his cock out, sticking up straight from his fly, and she stroked her hand on him and let him see her watching it.

Now she was slinking down the couch, getting low so he could feel her breath against the sensitive skin of his manhood. It was nice to provide a buildup.

She put her mouth over him, felt his hardness slip over the top of her pallet and she got him deep enough to trigger a gag reflex that she kept

quiet. Now she rolled her head, worked his fly open, slipped a hand inside his boxers and squeezed his balls.

She didn't look up, didn't think she was ready yet to see the face Max made when he got a blow job (nor did she want him yet to see her face with his cock pushed into it), just concentrated on doing it right. Concentrated on bringing him pleasure that he would remember. She used her tongue to pulse against his underside, swiveled her head and bobbed. Max wasn't one of those guys who thrust it deep, wasn't one of those guys who tangled his hand in your hair and fucked your face like he hated you. He was gentle and permissive. And she liked it. It suited him.

"Oh no, wait, wait," he groaned, and now she felt his hand on the back of her neck.

She withdrew and stroked his cock fast with her hand. He made a reluctant sound of pleasure, arched his back but kept his butt planted in the coach seat. She put a hand between her and his penis so he wouldn't come in her face. Hot splashes squirted against her palm, and then she gripped him hard and squirmed her wet hand to bring it all out of him. Max just about died.

SOMETHING WAS WRONG, and she felt it. Max was moving her hand out of the way, pushing his penis back inside his pants and zipping up. She wiped at her mouth, returned to sit next to him. With her elbow up on the back of the couch she regarded him, but he wouldn't look at her. He was struggling with something to say, and she didn't know if she wanted to wait for it. When he didn't say anything, she said, "It's getting late."

Now he nodded, raised his eyebrows, prepared to say something then bailed out again. His eyebrows went low. He turned to regard her and they looked into each other's eyes.

She said, "I'll sleep on the couch."

"No, you... Take my bed."

She said, "I won't take your bed, Max."

They stared at each other again, both of them with their mouths open waiting to say something. He did first.

"What was that? What did we just do?"

It wasn't the reaction she would hope for. She said, "Did I do something wrong?"

He shook his head no. "I think I did," he said and ran both his hands through his hair, lay back on the couch seat and looked across the room.

"What did you do wrong?"

He said, "Please, take my bed."

"No, Max, I won't."

He said, "I can't believe that just happened," and ran his hands through his hair again.

She said, "Yeah, I can't believe it either." This was bad. This was Maggie's ex-boyfriend. Why did she do that?

Now she was reaching across the table and getting her phone.

Max said, "Wait, what are you doing?"

"I think I should go. I'm calling a cab."

Max put his hand over her phone. "Don't. I mean it. I want you to stay."

"Max, I think I should go."

He said, "Come to bed with me. Just come and lay in the bed with me. We'll both sleep in the same bed."

What a terrible idea. "I don't think I should."

"Yes, you should." He was holding one of her wrists with both hands.

She said, "No. I don't really think you want me to."

"Look, I'm sorry. I just..." He shrugged and shook his head, let her wrist go, put his hands up. "I don't even know..."

Shoot, shoot, shoot. She dialed for a taxi.

AT THE DOOR, Max was still convincing her to stay. "Please, come on. Maggie will kill me."

"Maggie will kill you because I didn't stay?"

And there he was running his hands through his hair again.

She said, "Seriously, Max, that's what I was going to do. I have a hotel room. It's fine."

"It's not fine," he growled. "Just cancel the cab. Please, I want you to stay here."

"Max, I think I made a big mistake."

“No, you didn’t,” he said, his body contorting with some inner struggle she no longer wanted to know about.

“Max, I *know* I made a big mistake. Whatever you do, please don’t tell Maggie.”

His head rolled on his shoulders. “I won’t,” he said. “Shit...”

She said, “I gotta go, okay. Thank you so much for coming with me tonight. I mean it. You were a great companion.”

“Keely, please...”

“Max, both of us will feel better when this is done and I’ve walked down the hall and got on the elevator and you know it. This... tonight... just never happened. Okay?”

“We can... okay, it didn’t happen, but stay here. I’ll sleep on the couch and you take my bed...”

“You’re a good guy, Max,” she said, and she kissed his cheek. He squeezed her arms but let her go.

She was at the elevator when he caught up to her. He had shoes and his jacket on. She said, “Where are you going?”

“I just want to make sure you’re safe...”

AFTER MAX HAD ESCORTED her to the taxi out front of his building, they fumbled their way through another awkward goodbye. The whole ride back to her hotel she kept her jacket’s hood up so the cab driver wouldn’t want to ask her anything. God, what a dolt she was.

Four-and-a-half hours of sleep left her feeling far from refreshed and she skipped breakfast, opting for a coffee and a cookie at the cafe in the train station. She slept a little on the train back to Boston. She should have been studying.

Now it was just after six and she stumbled into Lowell with her bag over her shoulder and she stunk like B.O. and she could smell whisky in her hair. What a damn mess she’d made of it.

Martina was out, so she got her kit together to have a shower. Her phone dinged in her bag and she had an inkling of who it was so she didn’t answer it, went down the hall instead to scrub smells and bad feelings away.

When she returned, she checked the phone. Sure enough, it was bad. Not Max, as she'd anticipated, but maybe worse.

Maggie: how did it go?

Maggie: you home yet or on the train?

Maggie: call me when you get in

Oh, Maggie, oh, Maggie, I did something awful.

Oh no, what happened?

I sucked off that guy you set me up with.

The one I was engaged to?

That's the one, but you know—he didn't want me to do it.

Oh, how awkward for you. And by the way I hate your guts now.

A phone call was out of the question so she texted Maggie back, standing in her darkening dorm room in a robe, and her hair wrapped in a towel.

Keely: just got home

Maggie: long trip

Keely: the worst

Maggie: I hate the train

Keely: tell me about it I fell asleep and I was worried someone would have their hand up my skirt when I woke

Maggie: ur brave falling asleep

Keely: brave or not very smart

Wasn't that the truth.

Maggie: how's Max?

Keely: he's good

Maggie: how was the party? u mvng to NYC ha ha?

Keely: great. I was all worked up about nothing

Maggie: that's good u want to come over later?

Now she winced. Thumbs paused over the phone ready to type a response, she chickened. Her hands dropped to her side. She sighed, looked at the ceiling at the passing headlights drawing rectangles on the roof and scratched at her neck. She sat down, looked at her phone again.

Keely: I'm beat and I slept on the train so I didn't get any work done I have to study tonight

Maggie: OK u want to come by tomorrow?

Keely: will try

She winced again. It was so obvious that she was trying to avoid her, and Maggie was not stupid.

Maggie: everything all right?

Keely: everything's good

Maggie: was everything good with Max?

Keely: perfect gentleman

She closed her eyes and tapped her phone against her forehead, grimaced when she heard the ding of Maggie's response.

Maggie: he is, he's a good guy

Keely: you got that right I gotta go okay? I got people for my study group here I'll talk to you later

Maggie: 👍

Keely groaned, drew her arm back like she was ready to launch her phone over a hurling field, just dropped it onto the bed and watched it bounce. She flopped onto her belly and buried her face in her hands. Groaned into them. What a terrible thing she'd done...

Yardbirds

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2

MONDAY, after class ended at 4:30, she went to a study group that met at the tables on the first floor of the Widener. There until six, she then went across the street to the Subway and she got a half a meatball sub, a bag of chips, and a Diet Coke. Brought that back to her dorm room, ate it and watched an hour of Netflix before she studied again. It was 10:15 when her phone buzzed; she took her earbuds out, rolled to her back and looked at the screen. Shit. Max Milton calling.

She avoided it, dismissed the call and rolled to her stomach again, folded her forearms under her chin and stared at Martina.

Martina said, "We're back to sad Keely again."

"I'm not sad," she said, her head bouncing around as her chin moved.

"You're certainly not happy like you were last week."

"I know, I know," she said and rolled onto her back.

Her phone rang again. She checked. Max Milton. She dismissed it again.

Martina nodded her chin toward the phone, said, "That your affair of the heart?"

"On the phone?"

"Yeah. Somebody chasing you down?"

"Yes." And her mouth remained open as if she would continue; maybe explain to Martina what an idiot she was. There were few who would understand what an egregious error she'd made, and Martina would not be one of them. She was one of the ones in the 98th percentile for purity. *You*

put your mouth on his before you were married? Wait, not on his lips? You mean... down there?... Her mouth closed with an audible pop.

Now her phone buzzed again, and she sighed, getting exasperated. She ran her fingers through her hair and growled. It was a text this time. From Max.

Max: I'm outside. I know you're there. Please just answer the phone

"Holy shit," she sighed.

Martina looked excited, said, "What is it?" Some welcome drama was being injected into her evening.

"Nothing. It seems I can't ignore this one."

"This the one that's Maggie and Cole's friend?"

"Yes, he is. Hold on." She cleared her hair away from an ear and tapped his name. Phone rang, and he picked it up before the end of the first ring.

His tinny voice: "Hello?"

She said, "What do you mean you're outside?"

"Right outside your door. I'm afraid to knock..."

Her heart began to thud. She raised her chin up and stared at their dorm room door with the towels hanging off it.

When she didn't answer, he said, "I'm kidding. I'm in Cambridge."

"Oh."

"That's a relief, huh?"

She gave a funny chuckle.

"Keely, would you come and meet me, please?"

"Meet you where?"

"I just want to talk."

"I'm supposed to be studying."

"I came a long way just to talk to you."

She flopped back on her bed with her head on the pillow. "You're not here to see Cole and Maggie?"

"I haven't seen them at all. I want to talk to you."

She sat up again. "You do?"

"I don't like what happened between us—the way it ended."

She groaned. *Tell me about it.*

He continued: "You know? Not like that, don't groan—not that ending. There were things I should've said. I came all this way to say them."

"Yeah, all right. Hold on," she said, scooting off her bed.

Before she hung up he said, "Wait..."

"What?..."

"Where are you going to meet me?"

"Oh, that's right," she laughed. "I had a picture of you in my mind standing outside my door."

"I don't even know where your dorm room is."

"Well, where are you?"

"You want to meet me in the Yard?"

SHE'D THROWN TOGETHER the casual yet contrived look of a young, studious college girl, trying to prove she was busy. Sweatpants, thick socks and Birkenstocks; Harvard sweatshirt and her Patagonia jacket over top. She bounced around her room while Martina was saying, "What's happening? What's happening?" She'd said, "I don't know. I'm supposed to go out and meet him..."

She put on lipstick. Looked in the mirror and rolled her eyes. Removed it with a cloth. Put on lip gloss. She tousled her hair, hung it down both sides of her face. Changed her mind, drew it back in a ponytail. Too high. Moved the tail below the crown of her head. Better.

Though she hurried down the steps and raced along Plympton Street to get to the Yard, now she was slowing her roll; trying to look a little less excited. Hands in pockets worked, and she looked in the windows of buildings she passed before walking into the Harvard green space. Max was waiting for her under a tree near the John Harvard statue where he said he'd be. He had his hands in his pockets too, and she got the impression he'd been walking in a circle. On a bench under the tree she saw two steaming cups of coffee.

When they got closer together, he smiled. He received her, putting his hands out and pulling her into a kiss on the cheek. He said, "How are you doing?"

"Busy," she said

“I get it. I don’t want to take any of your time.”

“No, it’s all right.”

“I didn’t want to do this over the phone.”

“You drove four hours to come and tell me something?”

He rubbed his hand over his head, scratched his fingers through the back of his hair. “Four and a half.”

“This must be something amazing.”

He turned away from her, saying, “I don’t know if it is.”

“Is this for me?” she said, pointing to the coffee.

He said, “Two creams?”

She tested him for no reason: “No sugar?”

He frowned. “No sugar.”

“Oh, you remembered,” she said, impressed.

He shrugged. “Yours is on the right.”

She took her coffee, smelled it before taking a sip—didn’t want to get roofied in Harvard Yard, maybe this guy was here to strangle her with her panties. Then again: what did Roofies smell like?

Max said, “Do you want to sit down?”

“This must be some doozy.”

“Stop. I really do have something important to say.”

Now she was on the defensive. She said, “You probably should. I have to say that was the very worst reaction I’ve ever seen to something like that.”

“Sorry.”

“I thought I was pretty good at it.”

He wasn’t laughing tonight. She was trying to get him going, but he wasn’t in the mood. This was the obverse Max. Cynical Max, Wise Max made hard by the wounds of the world was replaced now with Somber Max. She set her coffee cup down to listen.

He said, “Look...” Then he had trouble continuing. He sat down next to her, both of them facing the same direction, looking out the brick archway of Johnson Gate onto Massachusetts. “I don’t know. I am sorry. I don’t know why I reacted like that.”

“Go on.”

“I feel guilty.”

“Why?”

Max turned his coffee cup around in a circuit, thumb flicking at the flared plastic rim. "It's so complicated. But... I'm seeing someone."

She did *not* see that coming. Her head drifted back and her eyes fluttered. She made a disgusted coughing sound and wanted to get up and walk off. "You're seeing someone?" she said, "You never even mentioned it."

"I know."

"You're seeing somebody, you don't even mention it to me? What kind of thing is that to do?..."

"It's not like that..."

"You don't mention somebody you're seeing when you want to get *something*—you know what I mean? And you certainly got it..."

"Don't be mad. It's not like that at all." He was firmer now, actually pointing at her, instructing her to calm down. She wanted to grab his index finger and bend it right back. Her face had gone sour.

Max said, "It's really not like that. If it was like that, would I come to you now? Come to you and want to tell you?"

"No. I suppose not."

"So, please, just listen."

"Fine. I'm listening." She still had a vision of her with a grip on that finger, twisting it back, making those cherry lips curl in a snarl. "So what's the big news? Who is it you're seeing?"

"Oh boy," he said. He looked up at the stars, rolled his head around on his neck and flexed his shoulders.

She hated his stalling, said, "Does Maggie know you're seeing someone?"

"Yes. She does."

"Oh, really? Because she never said it to me. She never said it at all..."

"You talk to Maggie?..."

"About you?"

"Yeah."

"We have better things to talk about. We're busy girls..."

He waved her off now, getting mad, though she could sense it wasn't necessarily directed at her; it was the situation in general.

She asked, "Seriously—you told Maggie that you're seeing somebody?"

"Look... What happened between us... it was entirely my fault."

"Well I'm glad you see it that way."

“I don’t want you to feel bad.”

“I’ve got thick-skin Max. You think I cried myself to sleep?”

He rolled his eyes now, and she pictured slapping his cheek; it made her stifle a smile.

He said, “Keely, I care about you. We had a great night and... I’m not that kind of guy.”

“I bet your girlfriend might say you are.”

He was silent for a moment; didn’t even react to her quip. He said, “It’s Maggie.”

“What’s Maggie?”

Max turned to her now, and she could see passing streetlights reflected in the wet on his pupil. He was earnest. He said, “Would you do me the favor of not telling anybody.”

“Telling anybody what?”

“It’s Maggie I’m seeing.”

“What do you mean?” She could feel her face tightening as if it was constricting to a pinched point around her nose. What he was saying made sense, but her brain couldn’t put it together...

He said, “Don’t tell anybody. It’s Maggie. The other girl is Maggie.”

She tried to say ‘what’ three times but only the W’s formed. Sound kept getting choked off; she was shaking her head erratically. She wanted to laugh.

He said again: “Please, don’t tell anybody. We used to let people know, but...”

“She’s cheating on Cole?” she said, extending her hands out and showing her palms. Bewildered by disbelief.

“She’s not cheating.”

“You were engaged,” she said, loud and high, like she’d just found something she’d been looking for. Now she was pointing at him.

He gave a sad half-smile. “She told you that?”

“What do you mean you’re seeing her?”

“I don’t know. It’s complicated...”

“Wait, you used to let people know...?”

“She’s not cheating. Cole knows.”

It paralyzed her. “I’m sorry, I don’t understand.”

“The three of us are okay with it.”

“You were engaged to her.”

He nods.

“And now you’re in a threesome?”

“Yeah. I am.”

“Is this personal—do you sleep with her?”

“It’s personal.”

“Oh, you can’t tell me...?”

“It’s not like that. It’s just it’s her business too. She has to tell you...”

Bewildered, she quietly said to herself: “She practically set me up with you.”

“Did she?”

“What does that mean?”

Max put his head down and clasped his hands between his thighs. “I don’t know what it means.”

“You see it though?”

He nods.

“I should have told you before anything happened between us. I didn’t see it coming, you and me.”

“Are you saying I move fast?”

“Oh no, I just mean—”

“Relax, I’m joking,” she said, though there was no humor in her voice.

Max smiled. “I didn’t even know it was a date we were on.”

“You’re just normally that charming?”

“You think I was charming?”

She clutched handfuls of her ponytail and clamped them around her neck, staring holes in the concrete ahead of her. “Jesus, Max, I went down on you...”

Max was quiet, and now she was inundated with flashes of Maggie in the Stacks, crying, saying how she was such a match for Max. You’re kind of just like him...

Now more was coming: A three-way. All three of them in bed? Max, Maggie, Cole, all naked and writhing around together... Cole’s innuendo, Maggie’s chastising, Max not wanting to drive her home... he’d just drove all the way from NYC to get a piece of Maggie’s tail. Three complicated demons drawing an innocent into their magic for the sake of a spell, or the Greek Gods at battle while the humans suffered. She suddenly felt incredibly small.

She drew in a long breath then let it out, lifted her head and looked around her. A Derek-size headache seized her shoulders and licked up her neck, tightening her scalp and throbbing through her temples unwelcome. A strong desire for a drink wormed through her forethoughts. Her tongue rubbed her palette, thirsty for a splash of whisky. “Well, this bloody sucks.”

“I’m sorry,” he said.

She looked at him. He seemed distant and foreign now. Far, far away, dirty, dark, and as untrustworthy as her immigrant ancestors were.

All she’d amounted to was a way for some hot girl to slough off an extra boyfriend; all that crap about *Don’t tell him we talked like this, Keely*. Her new friends. She’d been had. Never had she felt so young and stupid. And manipulated. Just a means for Maggie to have a problem taken off her hands. But if Maggie didn’t want her to mention their discussion—her setting them up!—it meant the biggest loser of the night was this handsome fellow with her. The man who didn’t know his three-way relationship was over.

“This is way, way too much, Max.”

“We used to tell people, but, yeah, it proved too much.”

“Nah, I mean it. I should go.”

“Keely, I’m sorry...”

“You’re good, Max, and I appreciate you coming all this way to tell me in person. You’re a good man, I mean it. I think I need to hang out with people my own age.”

“Please, don’t be mad at me. Or Maggie...”

Poor Max didn’t even see it yet.

She had class in the morning, two books to read, a paper due the following Monday; the last thing she needed now was to be embroiled in the most fucked up love quadrangle of all time; one she never requested to enter. Max reached for her and she drew back, two hands up at her shoulders with palms facing him, showing him touching was a no-go.

“No, Max, I’m not mad. Whatever the three of you have going on I support it fully, believe me. But I want no part of it in any way. Okay?”

“I respect that, Keely.”

She stood now, facing away toward the road, thrust her hands in the pockets of her coat. She turned to face him. “Thank you for the coffee. Thank you for the courtesy, too, I mean it. You’re too good for them.”

“I’m not.”

“You might not think you are, but you are. You take care, Max Milton, you hear me?”

“I hear you.”

She bent now, cupped his ear and kissed the top of his head. He touched her arm. “I mean it: I thank you for coming. You take care, okay?”

“Okay.”

She patted his arm but avoided looking in his eyes, turned, hands back in pockets, and headed out to the traffic on Massachusetts, looking to get home.

Give Me A Break

WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 4

KEELY WAS ON HILLIARD STREET, standing on the brick sidewalk opposite Maggie's house. It was a cold and blue night, but the square of her friend's kitchen bay window shone with amber warmth. Maggie's shadow moved around against the curtain.

She'd been putting this off.

Now she walked two house lengths down the sidewalk, turned around, brought up the hood of her down jacket. She had her hands thrust in her pockets and had been practicing what she would say all afternoon.

All she had to do was knock on the door.

It was harder than she thought.

But she was committed, striding across the narrow street to the sidewalk on Maggie's side, making a turn to arrive at the steep, three-step walkway to the colonial portico.

Fake cotton cobwebs still spun in the shrubs by the buzzer, and she gathered them up into a clump in her fist and rang the bell. She waited, shivering, backed down one step when she saw movement behind the glass partition.

Maggie opened the door, face poised in some sort of relief; glad to see her. She smiled.

Keely tried not to look too sheepish, then said, "Trick-or-treat." She presented the wadded up spiderweb.

Maggie took it, passed it from hand to hand looking at Keely standing below her. She said, "Can you come in?"

"I'd like to," she said.

Maggie stepped back and held the door for her and she came into the narrow hallway. She said, "I was just making some tea. Would you like a cup?"

"I would," she said, taking off her jacket and hanging it on the coat rack. There was a plastic skeleton and a cut-out witch propped in the corner that hadn't been put away yet. She said, "Did you have a pumpkin?"

Maggie said, "Some kids stole it. Come on into the kitchen," and she walked down the hall.

Keely slipped her shoes off and followed in her stocking feet. She found Maggie in the warm light of the kitchen with her back to her. A copper kettle billowed steam on the stovetop, sending out a bright whistle. She removed it and filled a teapot. With her butt leaned on the stove, she reached over and opened the container of teabags, getting another one to add to the brew since there would be two of them. Maggie popped it in to the teapot, set the lid on. Arms crossed, butt still against the stove, she asked, "Is there a reason you're avoiding me?"

Keely shrugged, stood there next to the kitchen table with her hands curled over the crest rail of one of the chairs. Maggie had been working, one of the other chairs pushed away, notepads, laptop, and textbooks spread in a clutter. There was a glass of wine. She said, "I guess so."

Maggie grimaced, put her hands together and rested them over her sternum. She said, "You had a good time with Max?"

"I did. He was an excellent chaperone."

"That's good." Maggie lowered her eyes. "You two got along?"

"We did... I don't know what to say..."

"You can tell me the truth."

"No, I know. I want to. I just don't know what to say..."

"What happened?" She looked tense and nervous.

Keely said, "We went to the function. Max was smart and funny, he didn't embarrass me. He was a gentleman..."

"What did you do after?"

"We took a walk in the park..." She moved the chair out, reached to the sideboard where there was a lineup of sparkling clean wineglasses. She set one down on the table and sat by it. "You mind?" she said, nodding to the wine. Maggie shook her head no and Keely poured herself a glass.

Maggie said, "What park? Central Park?"

"No. One by his apartment."

Maggie made that funny grimace again; made a small fist over her stomach.

She said, "His apartment's by the restaurant. The park was between the two."

"Did you go to his apartment?"

"I did. I went there to call a cab, and we waited together."

"Okay."

She paused, had thought she might tell some more truths but now changed her mind. She exhaled, reached for the glass and drained it. Maggie poured two cups of tea, brought them to the table and Keely could see her hands were shaking.

"Thank you," she said, taking the tea the rest of the way and setting it down next to the wineglass.

Maggie stirred a small silver spoon in her plain tea for a few moments, watching it. Keely added sugar to hers and waited. Still watching her spoon, Maggie asked her: "Did you stay over?"

She bit the inside of her cheek. "No, I ended up going back to my hotel room." She could see Maggie slump and knew it was relief. She said, "There's more..."

Maggie said, "More?" Her voice had pinched tight.

On the other end of the sideboard by the kitchen table, just below the bay window, there was a plastic orange pumpkin with a gap-tooth smile. Light shone through it, and she could see there were candies in it. She got up from the table, chair legs scraping on the hardwood floor, brought the pumpkin back to the table with her, got out a two-piece Kit Kat. She waved it at Maggie. "Is this okay? Just with my tea..."

Maggie looked like she might be sick. She said, "No, go ahead, help yourself. If you don't eat them, I'll eat them. Or Cole. He's had a dozen today."

"Where is he?"

"Playing basketball."

She nodded, opened the wrapper of her chocolate. "Okay. So listen..." She hesitated, broke the Kit Kat in half, stomach twisting.

Maggie said, "What is it?"

"He came to see me the other night."

"Max did?"

She nodded. "The next day. Drove all the way here from New York City."

"Oh. Oh no..." Maggie's mouth worried itself into a thin line.

"You know why?"

"Why he came to see you?"

"He had something to tell me."

Maggie was squeezing her own bent fingers, knuckles white, worming around so hard against each other her hands shook. Maggie said, "Did you sleep with him?"

It was way too forward. Way too personal. Even though she hadn't—although she *had* done something—it wasn't something she would answer. She said, "You can't ask me that."

"I'm sorry," Maggie said, and she could see her eyes had gone pink.

Keely admitted: "I didn't."

"You didn't?"

"No. I didn't."

"What did he come to see you for?"

"He wanted to tell me something that you didn't. I guess he thought that if we were going to get to know each other better, he should be honest."

Maggie's hands unwound from each other, and she moved back from the table, leaning in her chair as if she were exhausted. She wiped at her eyes. "What did he tell you?"

"He said that while he liked me, he was seeing somebody."

"Seeing somebody?"

She submerged half the Kit Kat in her tea and gave it a steady dunking. "Yes. Is that news to you?"

"No. I don't know. I guess so..."

The Kit Kat was carefully bitten in half, keeping the chocolate off her lips. She took a sip of the tea before finishing the other half. She wiped her knuckle over her lower lip, said, "It was quite shocking to hear it. You know, I was going out with him. Or at least I thought so. I thought we were on a date..."

"It wasn't really a date."

"No, it wasn't. Did you know he was seeing somebody when you sent me?"

Maggie's eyes were wider now, but she wouldn't meet Keely's gaze. She just shook her head no.

“Let me tell you what he said.”

Maggie pushed papers around, set her elbows down on the table and rubbed her cheeks.

“You know what I’m going to say, don’t you?”

“I think so.”

“It was quite the shocker. Imagine that—I get set up on a date by someone, a friend, it turns out she’s sleeping with the guy she sets me up with.”

Maggie groaned as if she was wounded. She pushed herself back from the table. She said, “Keely, it’s *so* complicated.”

“Sure, it’s complicated. I get that. I’m sure it’s very complicated. But just one little sentence would make such a difference. Put the whole thing in perspective, like. One sentence. That’s all it took. Your man Max came all this way and set me straight and he could’ve texted it in ten words. He is a gentleman.”

“He is.” She laughed; a nervous, uncomfortable sound. Keely watched her long, fine fingers scrawl across her neck as she tugged on the collar of her shirt, looking up at the ceiling. “So what are you saying? He’s better than me?”

“Why did you do that to me?”

“I didn’t do it to you...”

“You’re in a three-way relationship?”

Maggie threw her hands up, shook her head. The kitchen was too silent with neither of them saying anything, and Maggie started to smooth her hair over and over again.

Keely said, “You’re in a three-way relationship. You were engaged to him and now you’re done?”

Maggie shrugged.

“Tell me, is it your decision or Cole’s?”

“Why does it matter?...” Then before Keely could answer: “It’s mine.”

“And it was your decision to use me?”

“I didn’t use you... How?”

“Oh, come on, Maggie. You used me to break up with him.”

“No, I didn’t.”

“Yeah, you did,” she said, feeling her brow lower and her head begin to nod, winding forward. “You’re in a three-way, yeah, but you’re done with him? Just break it off, don’t manipulate me because you’re afraid to do it.”

“I am afraid. I am afraid. You’re right, but it’s not like that. I’m not using you.”

“You are. You did.”

“I’m not. I love him, Keely, I love him, but it’s time for me to move on, time for me to get serious.”

“With Cole.”

Maggie nodded, looked down at her hands rubbing her thighs. They stilled. “I want to move on with Cole. He graduates next year.”

“Why wouldn’t you tell Max? You love him.”

There was no arguing against it, but Maggie still struggled to be right—though showed weakness now, her head rolling back on her neck, her blinking eyes looking up at the ceiling. She said, “Because I’m afraid to hurt him.”

“So you hurt me instead. You use me... I guess ‘cause I don’t matter.”

“What?—you matter, Keely, this is what I’m saying. I’m not using you. I love him and he needs you. Or someone like you, if you like him. You’re perfect for him. I know Max so well. I know him better than Cole.”

They were quiet a moment, both of them looking at each other, Maggie wanting to be the next one to speak but unsure of what to say, and Keely stomping down the still-swelling anger inside her.

Maggie said, “I love Max dearly. I always will. I get Max. Max doesn’t get me like Cole gets me. Cole gets me. He knows me so deeply, and I never saw that coming. I want that for Max. I want him to have that in his life. It won’t be me. I want it to be you. I think you get him.”

“You should have tol’ me that, yeah? I’m out. This is far more than what I’m looking for. Handing me off your castaway. A man in a threesome who the others don’t want anymore?”

Maggie’s mouth went slim, her chin dimpled and here came the tears again. “I want him. I’ll always want him.”

“Yeah, right.”

Tears rolled now, and she hated that it made her glad.

She got close to her, scooting the chair nearer, said, “You know what you have to do. I’m ashamed it wasn’t obvious. You should be ashamed. You say you love him...” she waited so Maggie looked up, said: “But you’re scraping him off your shoe.”

Maggie’s mouth dropped and her eyes went wide. Then her mouth closed again making a soft pop. Then she exhaled, eyes drifting down. Tears

swelled and her eyelashes fluttered, casting off drops before two new tracks raced down the soft curve of her cheeks. “Holy shit, Keely, please, please don’t say that.” Her voice was a pained whisper.

“It’s true isn’t it?”

She gently pleaded, “Help me help him, please.”

“No. I won’t. I’m not your toy.”

Then Maggie changed. The sadness disappeared, she sniffed, sat straighter though her hands were clutched in her lap and her shoulders still sloped. She drew in a breath, her expression falling to neutral, her eyebrows losing their pinch, the furrow knit between them smoothing away. She said, “Take it back.”

“Take what back?”

“Scraping him off my shoe. That’s not true. Take it back.”

Now she sat straighter. “I won’t.”

Maggie said, “You’re wrong.”

She said, “*You’re* wrong.” Now she stood, saying, “All that boo-hoo in the Stacks? You’re a manipulator, yeah.”

“I’m not,” she said, “there’s just no way I could have explained it to you.” Her stronger posture faltered and her expression sagged to sadness again.

“You didn’t even try,” she said, not the best line to turn a heel on but it would have to do. She left the table and went down the hall, put on her shoes and jacket. She pivoted again and marched back to the kitchen, found Maggie poised rising from the table.

“The worst is I don’t believe you about Derek. How about that? You needed me to do something but Derek was in the way. That’s what I think.”

Maggie’s face went firm, her pouted lips tightened. “You failed to mention you slept with Cole at Farm.”

She scoffed, shook her head. “Weak, Maggie, that’s weak. I didn’t mention it because I *like* you, not because I needed you to do something for me.”

Maggie looked back expressionless but for a slight downturn to all her features; a forlorn woman trying to hold it all together.

Now she turned on her heel again—*this was much better*—and stomped down the hall to the front door.

Maggie didn’t say a thing, didn’t even follow.

PART 2

Duo

DECEMBER 18 - DECEMBER 20

Snowball

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 18

IT'S NOT like he hadn't seen it coming. He'd been standing on the tracks a long time feeling the distant rumble and knowing what it was, knowing it would soon be here. He'd never stepped off the tracks to save himself.

At least he'd seen it coming.

It can't go on like this anymore, Max, no matter how we love you.

Wow.

The two of them together, Maggie and Cole, sitting on the couch, him on the loveseat. The room quiet but for Boccherini on vinyl. He'd stared at his wineglass and wondered if he would cry. He didn't. Not in front of them. Not that night.

For three years they'd engaged in a three-person relationship. One beautiful and amazing woman and two good friends. But from that moment when she'd rejected the return of his engagement ring, standing on the snowy shore of a frozen pond in upstate, things were never the same. They were never a couple the same way they'd been before the careless charade they played at the end of college. Too much damage had been done. Him to her, her to him. In fact, it was amazing they'd even stayed friends. But that was love. Love was stronger and more enduring than sensibility and bad decisions. Even now, he knew he loved her, and, though crazy, she loved him in return.

The time they'd spent together as three, while not the same as when they were two, was also love. But he never felt like he had more than a *share* of her. Not the whole. When Maggie looked at Cole the way he wished she only looked at him, he felt pain. For whatever reason, he'd been

assigned a makeup that craved that awful feeling. Never understood how Cole could stand it when it was Max's turn to receive Maggie's attention. Some kind of duty or maybe an apology or reparation for past events. Most likely all of those things.

One thing was sure, and it became crystal clear as time passed. There was genuine love between them. Cole loved Maggie. If Maggie told him she needed her Maxy, loving Cole would give it to her. Love between Cole and Maggie grew in his absence and while he hated the fact, it was true: her love for him diminished. Proximity played a role for sure. He was in NYC, they were here in Cambridge, but that arrangement was Maggie's choice. He held close to his heart the fact that diminished love was still love.

Nope, he couldn't say he didn't see it coming.

So now here he was, by himself at Christmas, away from his apartment, staying at their home again. Like he couldn't keep away. They weren't even in Cambridge. Alone at the butcher, grabbing a steak for one that would pair well with the bourbon gifted by his boss. Two days away he'd be home in Michigan with family because he needed to be with someone right now. It was a bottomless feeling to be told by someone you loved that they were moving on without you. Even if you saw it coming, and even if they still loved you and you loved them. All he had right now was the ghostly echoes of their words that night and they were terrible company.

He'd said outright: "I saw it coming." Letting them off the hook.

"Nothing's going to change, Max." That was Cole. *Not change?* What did that mean? They could all still climb in bed together? But now he was an outsider. He would be with another man's girl.

"I'm thinking of you, Max." That was Maggie. Right. Good point. He'd spent the last few years not meeting girls because he was in love with Maggie. Instead of being forthcoming, Maggie had thrown Keely into his life like a hand grenade.

"We want to see you every week, dude. No change." Cole again.

"But your future is with Cole." That was him stating the obvious.

And so it was. He'd visited twice since then, though things didn't end up in the bedroom. He wasn't sure if he'd want that too soon. Or ever.

Bone-in prime ribeye dry aged for forty-seven days seemed like just the ticket to go with the Droptine's 12-Point. Paper wrapped by the butcher, he dropped it in the handcart with the produce and headed to the cashier check out decorated for Christmas with evergreen boughs, tinsel, and red bows.

Out on the street, he walked around his car, opened the door. He took a moment to close his eyes and feel the sun on his face. It was sunny, cold, and the Cambridge streets were edged with furrows of plowed snow.

The top of his head exploded with sudden bright pain.

A GOOD MOOD had settled around her shoulders like her Nan's favorite fuzzy shawl. Two days away she'd be back in Aughrim for Christmas, settled in by the fire. Her Da wasn't going to make it, crisis in Qatar, nor her brother, but her sisters were, and her mum. It would be an all-girls Christmas and much shenanigans were to be expected. It was college recess, and she'd come through so far in her final year with a 3.8 GPA. Many jobs were well done this semester, and she deserved congratulations even if they were mostly from herself. The sun was shining though it was cold, and the air was crisp on her cheeks.

Walking along Kirkland, heading for the bus into the city, dead ahead and unexpected: a familiar form strolled out of a shop and paused on the sidewalk under a black awning. A fella she'd thought about, wondered about, but stayed away from. Before she called out, he stepped ahead to his black Porsche parked street side beyond a barrier of snow, went round to the driver's door. She didn't *like* to call out, and people were walking her way. There were other ways to get people's attention, funnier ones, especially in winter. The window boxes of a gift shop at her side had their troughs of seasonal flowers replaced with a line of wet snow. She gathered a ball roughly the size of a grapefruit, palmed it in a multi-colored woolen mitt, hauled back and hoisted it high and far in the general direction of the man pausing now to feel the sun on his face.

The snowball had a wonderful launch, pausing about twenty feet above, seeming almost to hover a moment before its descent. But as it turned down, her fingers began to tingle, and she had an awful premonition it would be more on target than she'd intended.

She gulped in a whisper of frigid air that puffed her cheeks and held it, watched wide-eyed. Sure enough, the snowball came down exactly on the crown of the poor man's head and exploded in a twinkling shower.

"Oh fuck," she said, wincing, covering her mitts over her mouth.

Max's shoulders jumped up to his ears, and he hunched over. Snow shifted off his hair and down his face, and now he shook his head, ran a black leather glove up to brush it away. When he turned her direction he was scowling, eyes bewildered. She raised a harmless hand in greeting, said, "I had no idea I was such a good shot."

Max's expression weakened, but he didn't laugh. Head tilted to the side he shook more snow away.

"Aw, dammit," she muttered and trotted his way.

She went round behind him, brushed snow from his shoulders, whispering, "Sorry, sorry, sorry... Really, Max, I didn't mean to hit you."

He complained: "It's all down the back of my jacket."

"Is it cold?"

Now he turned to face her, brow down and pained. "It's snow."

She flashed a weak, teeth-gritted smile. "Are you mad at me?"

He didn't answer, leaning forward and shaking his shirt out. Snow fell from inside his coat and to his feet. She bit her lip.

Glove up and smoothing his hair back now, his eyes went up and down her. She showed him her palms to prove she was unarmed. He said, "No. I'm not mad. I'm glad to see you."

She smiled a little more. "How've you been?"

He shrugged. "Awful." His hands were together now at his front, fingers hooked around the twine handles of a paper shopping bag as he leaned against his car door.

"Oh, sorry."

He said, "I hear you're not talking to Maggie."

"I'm just taking some time for myself."

"You're killing her, she says."

"I'm not trying to. I did send her a birthday card. I don't know what to tell you..."

"You didn't return any of my texts."

Now she shrugged.

He opened the door without turning around, then stepped aside and tossed his bag into the passenger's footwell. Door closed again, he crossed his arms, looked up and down the street. He said, "You said she was setting us up."

She didn't answer.

"She was," he said, nodding, "she was setting us up."

“I know. Are you here in Cambridge to see them?”

He shook his head side to side.

“What’s happening there?”

“With them? Nothing. Nothing’s happening.”

“Are you still seeing her?”

He shook his head again, brow lowered, staring at the glistening pavement. He said, “No.”

“You’re still friends with them.”

“What am I going to do?”

“Get new friends.”

Max gave her a horrified look, insulted.

She said, “Just kidding, Max. They’re your friends.”

“They are.”

It was a little uncomfortable, him being sullen, the embarrassment she’d lobbed a snowball onto his head. She said, “I should get going.”

He asked, “How about you?”

“How about me what?”

“How are you doing?”

“Would you be upset if I told you I’m doing well?”

“No, I’d be happy for you.”

“Well, I’m doing well.”

Now he smiled, and it made her feel good. A trickle came down from the hairline at his temple and curved over the edge of his jaw. He said, “That’s really good. Why would I be bothered? You mean because I’m not doing well? I don’t want to drag everybody else down.” He paused, then added: “Are you seeing someone?”

That made her toes twitch in her boots. That was a funny question. But she had an awful answer for him. “I am. I’m seeing a few guys.”

“A few guys,” he laughed.

“Nothing serious. Nothing serious like that.” And she reached out and grabbed his wrist for some reason. Didn’t want him thinking of her going down on these two guys. She hadn’t had sex with either of them. But it was on the docket for at least one of them.

“No, I know,” he said, “and you’re busy with school.”

“School is a breeze. But, aye, it’s a big workload.”

“You should probably call Maggie.”

She let his wrist go, shrugged again. “Maybe someday I will.”

“Why are you mad at her?”

“I don’t know, Max. She was a good friend but everything got so complicated.”

“Because of me?—Hey, maybe you’d want to come and sit with me. Do you want a coffee?” He nudged his chin to the rear of his car, back the way from where she’d come. Twenty yards back there was a side street, and on the corner was a quiet looking neighborhood coffee shop and laundromat in an old wood-sided home painted a faded gray-green.

She looked around and bit her lower lip. She was supposed to meet Marcus to see a movie. She withdrew her iPhone from her pocket, looked at the screen. She took off her mitt and tapped out a message to him, put the phone back in her pocket. “I’d have *one* coffee with you.”

MAX BOUGHT her a cappuccino with a fern leaf drawn in the foam; he got an Americano. They took a seat together in the front window while in the adjoining room, washers and dryers hummed. There were people laughing and talking in there, but they had the cafe to themselves. Max got up to get sugar packets, came back and sat down across from her, making the table jostle and spilling some of her coffee over the side. “Sorry,” he said.

“It’s all right.” She dabbed the spill with a paper napkin.

The table was small, and they seemed very close, their faces only a foot apart. He laced his fingers together. She could smell a nice woodsy scent from him. She said, “You smell nice.”

He nodded. “Old Spice,” he said.

She laughed, sipped her coffee.

“Soap-on-a-rope?” she asked him.

“What’s that?”

“Don’t you have soap-on-a-rope? I used to get it for my dad back when we were in Ireland.”

“Is it literally soap that’s on a rope?”

“It couldn’t be more descriptive.”

“It’s all in the name,” he said.

“They knew what they were doing. Or were unimaginative. We’ll never know.”

“So,” he said, “are you mad at Maggie?”

“I told you already. I just need some space.”

“She cares about you.”

“I suppose she does. Like I said, I just need space.”

“She didn’t want to hurt you.”

She took a risk. “Did she want to hurt you?”

It was a bad move. Max’s eyes shot straight up to the ceiling as if she jabbed him in the chin. The point of his tongue came up and touched the center of his plump upper lip. He looked wounded.

“Sorry.”

“It’s all right.”

“It’s been a bad month?”

“Second worst,” he said.

“There’s always someone out to get you.”

“You got that right.”

“So what happened?—Did she talk to you then?”

He nodded. “She’s moving on.”

“She is. I know. She told me.”

“Yes. Well, she’s told me now.”

His head came back to neutral, the bright light from the street shining on his dark hair, getting into one of his eyes and lighting up the colors. She took another sip of the cappuccino. “Are you all right?”

“I don’t know. I guess so. It’s been three years.”

“Three years that you’d been together?”

“As three?—Yes. I can’t say that I didn’t see it coming. I always hoped I could turn it around.”

“And then I came along.”

“You really ruined everything.”

Now it was her turn to look wounded—but that made him smile, and he made a brave move putting his hand over hers. She let him hold it. He said, “Only joking.”

“You don’t blame me, do you? I shouldn’t have done that...”

“It’s not you at all. I like you.”

“Oh please,” she said and rolled her eyes.

“Why? Is that crazy? I’m serious.”

“Anyway, go on.”

“I said I saw it coming. They’re living together here, and I’m in a different city altogether. At best I can see them once a week, but to be honest, this last year it’s probably been only twice a month. I could see it when I visited.”

“They play house.”

“It’s like I’m staying in *their* house.”

“Well, if you saw it coming...”

“I saw it coming, I just thought if I worked harder, did better, you know...”

“You thought you would win her by making money?...”

“When you say it, it sounds so stupid.”

“It is stupid.”

“I know it’s not about money. But it is...”

“No, it’s not.”

“You don’t understand.”

She sat back from the table, looked out the window at the passing cars. “I look at me dad, he makes a lot of money. What does it amount to? Is there love? His life can’t be measured in human relationships. It’s just work and money and power.”

“And it’s only Qatar.”

That caught her off guard and she laughed hard enough she slapped her leg. “Sorry,” she said and covered her mouth before she let out a horse laugh.

He was smiling. “But that’s exactly it. I don’t want to make more money, you’re right, I’m not saying it right. I want to *create* something.”

“Create money. So you can show off...”

“See, that’s where you’re wrong. Because it’s not that at all. I don’t want to compare families but I look at my dad—”

“Mr. Fix-it.”

“Exactly. Mr. Fix-it. He’s always there to help everyone. Do you know what I mean?...”

“I do. He’s a lawyer?”

“Yes. A lawyer, he invested in some small businesses... But if you asked him what mattered, it wouldn’t be any of that. And that’s what I’m saying, I just want to build something intangible but real.”

“Create your own minions from your loins...”

He looked to the ceiling wistfully as if she said the best thing ever. “Exactly. I want to make minions spawned from my own seed.”

“Your dad seems kinda malevolent now, doesn’t he?”

“Holy shit, you’re right. What a jerk. He just made a bunch of us to make himself feel powerful, lord over us...”

“Selfish bastard,” she said.

Now he was laughing. Hard enough he had to rub at his eyes. He took a napkin and dabbed. “That’s too funny. I should tell him that.”

“He’d get a kick out of it?”

“He sure would.”

“So that’s what you want to be like?”

“It is.”

“Well then, I take it all back.”

“How magnanimous of you.”

“I’m capricious, but with the wisdom of Solomon, and you’re lucky to have met my grace today.”

Then he did this: lifted her hand, kissed the knuckles and thanked her, addressing her as his grace.

KEELY WAS UNEXPECTED. The last thing he thought he’d be doing today was spending time with her. Because she was a nice, smart girl, and she’d been drawn into their badness, their weirdness; and just like how things happened between them three years ago, someone got hurt. This time it was an outsider. You’d think they’d have learned by now to be honest. It was deception that had ruined them in the first place. Though he supposed it had all worked out in the end, at least for Maggie.

In the aftermath of the Keely fiasco he’d extended more apologies to her that went unanswered, but paid no more unannounced visits. Maggie was heartbroken, she’d told him. Keely wouldn’t respond to her messages or calls and she was afraid to meet her face to face. Max told Maggie to give her time, but honestly figured they’d seen the last of her.

It was too bad, too, he’d thought, because there was something magical about the girl and it wasn’t just her looks. The evening he’d spent with her brought him back to a whole different time. A young time. A happy one.

The time before there was a Maggie tapped into his heart and siphoning off it through a hollowed metal spike. Also a time where he thought it was over between them and he was in control of their destiny, away and drunk in Chicago with his brother. A girl whose name escaped him sometimes, so he referred to her interiorly as Dora because of the costume she wore. And Keely was in his apartment, Halloween evening three years later. The significance wasn't lost on him. And while he'd seen his end soon coming with Maggie, he was content to keep nursing affection from her teat in the hope someday she would see the light; something amazing he would do, something maybe terrible Cole would do... But those tracks were rumbling under his feet, and he knew in his heart what would soon someday come. What he'd done with Keely that night in his apartment amounted to cheating. He'd been unfaithful to Maggie. It didn't matter that Maggie had sent her, offered her up. Part of him wondered if that was Maggie's game. To trap him into cheating so their relationship would be done.

But it was this girl sitting with him mid-day in a laundromat that was also a coffee shop that had roused him, brought up those spirits inside that reminded him of slick Max in high school who went through a lot of girls and had fun doing it. There was a thrill missing in his life and it must have come from the gradually diminishing love he'd felt from the girl he was supposed to marry. In the last year he'd become morose. Keely made him happy.

He wanted to know everything she would tell him about herself. Wanted to know all about her family, all about the Middle East, all about everything she'd ever done. He wanted to hear her laugh; he wanted to see her smile; he wanted to see the light flash in those unbelievable emerald eyes...

THEY SPENT the afternoon like that. She blew off a movie with Marcus. They had so many coffees her hands were shaking and she'd been in the loo four times. But boy was it good fun. She made him laugh, and he did the same for her. He talked about his family and she told him about hers. And just like that, they had moved the needle—not jumping forward but setting it back. Back to the night before she'd ruined it all by taking his penis out of his fly and putting her mouth on it. Right back to that point when

everything was sane, and they were just two young people sitting on the couch getting to know each other. She liked getting to know him. Maggie was right about one thing: she would never meet a nicer guy.

But when they left, and he was walking her to the car, he drifted behind then shoved a handful of snow down the back of her jacket. She liked a man who held a grudge.

Starlights

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 19

KEELY ARRIVED at the house on Hilliard Street at 7 P.M. with a bottle of red wine under her arm. Nothing too fancy; knowing nothing about wine she went by price tag. Sure, she went to Harvard and her parents did all right but it would seem she was not of the Becker family's wealth, so about \$17 was what she could part with. It better be all right.

The best part of the evening so far, standing on this stoop, was the excitement she felt. It had been a long time since she'd been this nervous to meet someone. The night she'd met Max in NYC there was so much more going on. All that stuff with the mayor's office, all the fears that she had made a mistake by not being forthcoming about her plans. There was a lot she was nervous about that night. Nerves were one thing; it was this unnamed anxiousness, a seamless swirling globe of possibilities that was breathtaking—it came on evenings where she knew she would be judging, she would be judged, and there was a chance she might share a kiss or two by evening's end with someone intriguing...

She rang the doorbell and waited. It was cold now, snowy wintertime. Maggie's quaint little federal home was hung with multicolored light bulbs along the eaves and drawing blinking squares around the windows. She wondered if it was Cole who'd put them up. She stomped her boots a little, hearing the man coming to the door now. The stoop was shoveled and salt put down. Very thoughtful, her Max.

"Hi, Keely, so glad you could make it," he said, opening the door and ushering her in.

She stepped into Maggie's foyer, saying, "You don't know how long it's been since someone offered me a good meal."

"I guess you're used to dorm food."

"Ugh," she said, "it's the worst. Here, this is for you," and extended to him the bottle of wine.

Max smiled and took it from her, held it in two hands so he could read the label. A saucy, Chilean carménère with a strong cocoa note (so the cashier told her). No reaction on Max's face, not giving anything away. Well, whatever. She was no sommelier and never pretended to be. Wine was wine, and she was sure they would both drink it until it was done.

Taking off her parka, she said, "When someone asks me if I'd like to have a good steak dinner, you know what I say?"

"I know what you say: I asked you, you told me."

"Oh, right. You did hear that."

Max put the bottle under his arm to take her coat from her. Gentleman. She watched him put it on a hanger and hang it in the front hall closet.

Now he led her to the kitchen, and she followed. She'd spent the day in the laundry—and she was shampooed and soaped—the clean smell of detergent billowing around her as she straightened her sweater. Max was looking good, too. Wool sweater, maybe cashmere, no collared shirt this time, going casual. He wore dark green corduroys and tan moccasins.

Coming into the kitchen, she said, "You're making yourself at home here?"

"Yeah," he said. "I booked my flight before... you know... I could have changed it to fly out of New York, but I still like being here. I fly out tomorrow..."

"Aye, I know, and me too."

"Right," he said. "You need a ride to the airport?"

Getting very comfortable her Max. She took a seat at the kitchen table while he went to check on the things he'd been preparing in the kitchen. She said, "What time you going?"

"My flight leaves at two."

"Mine's at 2:45."

Max said, "I can take you."

She shrugged, noncommittal. Maybe he would, maybe he wouldn't. They'd got along really well the last evening they were together yet there

she was at three in the morning going home in a taxi cab of shame. She changed the subject. "Maggie and Cole go to Rhode Island?"

Max was stirring a pot on the stove. He said, "Connecticut."

She said, "Connecticut? Cole's parents?"

"Yeah, they went out to see his folks for Christmas."

She said, "They going out to see her parents too?"

He said, "No. Her mom's working, and her father's in Europe or somewhere."

"I met her father."

A sliver of his profile was visible as his chin dipped and he watched the pot he stirred. There was a devious little twist to a small smile he held.

She asked him: "What's so funny?"

"Nothing," he said, "you were saying you met her father..."

Keely narrowed her eyes on him, studying him while he worked in the kitchen. She couldn't help a smile coming over her now, too. It was a risky move if she misread him, but she didn't think she did; she said, "At least I thought I did. Who knows with artificial intelligence these days; very lifelike, I imagine." And now she could see that small smile spread on his face and saw that he was trying to hide it from her.

Now she got up from the table, her hands in the pockets of her skirt, came up behind him to peer over his shoulder. "What are you making me?"

He smiled, looked in her eyes, let the topic of Maggie's father go and said, "Steak. Remember?"

"Right," she said, slow-nodding, "I caught you with a snowball coming out of Savenor's."

"That's right."

She squatted down and peered into the oven, saw the glimmering top of something baking, smelling rich of bread and onions. On the counter next to the cutting board there were two thick, seasoned steaks sitting there getting to room temperature before he cooked them. She said, "You got two of them..."

"I went back for another."

Her stomach did a funny little happy rollover, knowing he must have gone back to get another after she'd agreed to dinner. She said playfully, "Aw, just for me?"

"I like to entertain," he said. "I'm going to have company I want them to be happy."

“I don’t know if I told you or not, but a cooked dinner makes me happy.”

“I might have heard that,” he said.

They stood there quiet for a moment, her leaning her back against the stove while Max was next to her chopping potatoes. She said, “It reminds me of home.”

“Home and family.”

“You got that right,” she said.

“You spent a lot of time away?”

Now she turned, bent over and rested her elbows, getting close to watch his nice hands work the knife over the vegetables. She stroked the backs of her arms while she watched. She said, “There was a time, you know that age?—I like to say from eight to twelve, where I thought I was having my childhood. It was a time I thought this was what my life would be like. And then after that...?” She shrugged.

“I know that time. For me it was when we were all at home. My brothers and sister, my mom wasn’t sick, my dad was working and happy and excited about prospects. There was a four-year period of time like that—this little picture-perfect image that I’d like to have framed so I can put it on my desk.”

“It’s like that,” she said. She sniffed, worked her mouth from side to side. “Then it was off to boarding school, even though I was still in Aughrim I wasn’t at home. Then we traveled... I lived in France, that wasn’t for long, and I lived in Spain for half a year, I told you... And then after that we went to Qatar. It was just jumping around... One apartment to the next. I think I have four different school uniforms in my mum’s closet if she hasn’t sold them off yet.”

“Well, I’m glad I might cook you a meal that makes you think of the time when things made sense...”

She said, “Yeah,” taking a potato, palming it, then tugging up one sleeve and then the other. She took up a knife, said, “You mind?”

“Suit yourself,” he said.

She began chopping as well. “There was a time before I started boarding school when it was my brother, my sisters and me, and we went to my Nan’s for every Sunday dinner. She would do us up a big meal, and though it only had to be four years, it felt like every night of my life when I think back on it. It’s like it’s all I can remember.”

He smiled and nodded and she caught him peeking at her from the corner of his eye. They both watched each other's hands work at kitchen chores and listened to Brahms coming from the living room.

She flashed him a coy look, baited him, and he asked her: "What...?"

She said, "Now, Max, I know you're going to want me to ask you all sorts of personal questions about Cole and Maggie, and what it was like to be in a three-way relationship, a throuple for the hipper amongst us, but I flat out refuse..."

He gave her a look over his shoulder; cute mouth tweaked on one side, eyebrow high, a look of amusement. He said, "Oh no? What if I begged you?"

"You can try," she said, raising her eyebrows over half-lidded, uninterested eyes, "but it won't do you any good. I find the whole thing boring, to be honest. Not interesting at all."

"Not in the slightest?"

She mimed a yawn, covered it with her hand, turned away from the kitchen like she was bored, heard him snickering over the pan's sizzle as she dried her hands on a tea towel. Her fake yawn brought on a real one.

He said, "As much as I'd love to torture you with all the painful details, I guess we can talk about more positive things..."

TWO HAPPY, healthy—and horny—young adults breathed heavy sitting on a couch with their mouths together. Dinner was done, the plates were cleared, the dishwasher hummed. A small fire burned in a small fireplace. The walls of the family room flickered in warm orange. Syncopated white flashes danced with it; Maggie and Cole's Christmas tree in the corner behind the couch with its string of twinkling lights pulsing on and off. No presents under the tree, the homeowners away for Christmas. The tree was strung with plaid ribbon, decorated with paper poinsettias, and gold glass ornaments that reflected winking pinprick starlights on the walls. On the table: an empty bottle of Chilean wine. Also: a half bottle of an Italian red they found in a cupboard. Two empty wine glasses. The inside of her stocking knee rubbed up and down Max's thigh. His lips were soft and pillowy. When she bit them they felt ripe, like they might burst. She'd

kissed him before, but that night there had been hesitation from Max. In her as well. She liked this guy quite a bit. But she'd moved too fast. This was nice. They even kissed slow tonight. Sucking and biting and nibbling. Sometimes his lips would drift, and he would kiss below her ear. Her nipples were aching marbles in her bra. How long was it going to take this guy to give them a squeeze? She was even pressing her sweater-chest against him, urging him. She wasn't sure how far they would go tonight, but there was no sign yet of a stoplight. She was even moaning while she stroked him with her knee.

She sighed into his mouth when one of his hands found her breast at last. She wanted to cry out in joy just to make him laugh, but the humor was beginning to fade. There was a blazing fire roaring up in her belly, an urgent need, and the funny stuff was receding to the shadows.

His thumb found her hard bud through the wool of her navy sweater. He had good aim, stroking the cushion of his thumb in straight up-and-down lines, getting the exact spot. Now she gathered up fine cashmere in her fist as she squeezed her hand closed over his stomach. Her forearm pressed the hard bulk of his belt buckle, and she was counting down to the appropriate time her fingers might undo it. There was still a sting left from their last encounter, and all the explanations in the world weren't going to stop her being gun shy. Or penis shy, as it were—knock off the humor, Keely! But it was true. Max was going to have to make the moves here. But hand on breast and thumb on nipple were all good signs.

She did encourage him with this: bringing her head back, making him reach for her kiss now. And soon he was chasing her mouth, getting overtop of her. They were flat on the couch, and he was between her thighs. When she looked down their bodies, she could see one stockinged knee sticking up over his hip. She squeezed, brought her legs together to encourage him. God, he was a good kisser. Those lips! She could do this for a lot longer, Max could too, apparently, because he was taking his time. Most guys she knew—had she given them these signals—would have her skirt up over her face and be pounding her by now. And she wasn't opposed to that. But there was something exciting about how Max took his time. One might think it was shyness, or lack of confidence. But she was beginning to get the feeling that this Max fellow knew what he was doing. He seemed, of course, like the nice guy everybody said he was—*holy shit, stop saying it already, everybody! I got it!*—but as his hips began to grind into her and she could

feel his hardness through the corduroy pressing against the inside of her thigh, and yet he wasn't tearing her knickers down to get it in her, she thought there was something lurking underneath this nice-guy persona. How could this guy not know what he was doing being in a three-way relationship with one of the prettiest girls she knew, a wealthy one at that, and smart, who was also seeing a drop-dead gorgeous guy who could literally model for a living? Max had to bring something to the game. It wasn't an enormous penis, she already knew that. But he couldn't be a slouch, and that's why she let him take his time. Let's see where this was going to go, Mr. Milton...

Twenty minutes later and she was begging for it. She wouldn't give him the pleasure of putting it in words, but this guy had her humping her hips against him, both of them still fully clothed. Her coals were stoked; her hole was a raging furnace, and she needed this guy. Stop sign? Fuck a stop sign. This was all gates open, jangling bells holding back the sideways traffic, flashing green lights and blazing arrows saying This way! This way!

But still this guy stayed methodical. Now his hand was on the inside of her thigh, and she showed him her cards. Humping and scooting underneath him, shifting her butt across the couch seat until she felt the cup of his palm pressed between her legs. *You won't touch it?—I'll put it in your hand.* The heel of his thumb pressed over her stockings and panties, mashing down exactly where she wanted it. Of course, she'd offered it up, hadn't she? But he did this undulating thing, working his hand in a wavelike pattern, rolling and caressing over her mound and pushing down perfectly on her clit. God, he could probably feel it right through her clothing given the state he'd put it in.

Fuck a duck. She said, "Max, let's go upstairs..."

He bit at her chin, teeth dragging slowly; he looked into her eyes—no smile, but there was a fun connection there. Like she'd known him much longer than eight weeks. Like she'd known him since they were young.

She said again, "Let's go..."

He nodded, licked his lower lip. The kissing had brought blush to his cheeks, and his lips were swollen and large—she wanted to get naked and feel them pressed on all her delicate girl parts tonight.

"Yeah?" she said, biting her lip, eager.

"I think we should," he said.

Jesus, she was dying for it, and they hadn't taken a stitch of clothing off yet. She must've seemed like such a piker in his apartment that night, just taking his dick out and sucking it. Apparently when you're twenty-four and been around the block a bit, you took your time and made things last.

She sat up, felt dizzy. Max was stroking his thighs. She picked up the Italian red, dashed a little in the bottom of both glasses. Knocked hers back. She nodded toward his glass and he shook his head no. She knocked that one back too, softly clapped her hands together, said, "Let's go."

THE FLUTTERING she put in his stomach was intense. His muscles were jumping and twitching and his lips pulsed with excitement. This was not Maggie. But this was real. Very real. Right next to him, dashing a glass of wine back, was a beautiful twenty-one-year-old girl with fiery red hair and dazzling eyes, creamy skin, and, boy, did she want to fuck right now. His heart whooshed in and out, whisking frantic sounds in his eardrums.

NOW HE WAS LEADING the way upstairs; he put his hand behind him and she reached up to take it. He guided her to the landing, and they walked the narrow hallway to the door at the end of the hall. The door was open, and they passed into a cozy bedroom that looked like it had been decorated for a Ralph Lauren catalog. The centerpiece was the bed; an enormous padded leather beast that reminded her of an Edwardian couch with its rolled over footboard and headboard; the frame was gleaming mahogany; the leather set with pewter nail heads. Bedding in bright floral splashes, covered in pillows and cushions, the windows were dressed in shears and framed with a matching floral jabot that billowed to the gleaming wood floor. The wallpaper was toile, done in pink with illustrations of fox hunters on horseback.

She said, "What a beautiful... wait, is this *their* bedroom?"

Max didn't say yes but she could see him nodding.

She said, "Should we be in here?"

"There's no other room."

She squeezed her thighs together, looking at the bed where her friend Maggie and her lover slept every night. It wouldn't be the first time she used someone else's bed for an impromptu shag, but there was something uncomfortable about it. But with her thighs pressed together she could feel warmth in her seams. Could feel slickness there, too. And this strange, sullen, handsome man with a libertine past and a masterful touch had her firebed raging. She said, "This is so bad..."

"It's not," he said. No mirth.

"Are we going to do it on their bed?"

Max was taking off his sweater, giving her that sexy face; in this light the shadows made his cheeks look sunken and those kissable lips more kissable. He said, "We are."

Now, for some reason, she felt suddenly bashful. This guy was the most grown-up guy she'd ever been with. Her friend Marly went to uni in London and she dated a guy who ran his own business. That guy would've been in his thirties and Marly and her were barely nineteen at the time. She'd had dinner with both of them one night, and despite the fact the guy owned his own company—workout supplements, eye roll—he didn't seem like a man. His age was just a number. Max was only twenty-four, but she felt like a kid with him.

She was going to fuck Max on Maggie's bed, she knew it. That was fine... But now her hands were literally shaking. She looked down while Max unbuttoned his shirt, could see them trembling in the cold light coming through the sheers from the street. She tucked her hands up under her sweater—and the next thing she knew she was stalling...

She turned her back, but watched him in the mirror above the dresser. She said, "What terrible people... We're going to have sex in Maggie's bed..."

"We are," he said. "Take you things off." His voice was low and sure. Sweet Max had receded after he cooked their dinner, and now she was with someone else. She liked this one, too.

Still stalling, an unwelcome goofiness rising in her, she pulled open the top drawer, said, "Let's find where they hide all their whips and stuff." Joking, you know, killing time before she got undressed. But lo-and-behold, right there in the top drawer, there were indeed items of a fulfilling yet kinky sex life. Right up top: a vibrator. Gleaming in the light, looking like it was made of mercury. Also: bundled leather straps, and the bright curves of

brass buckles and rings. Holy shit. She swore that was a rubber ball in a woman's pantyhose. Some sort of ball gag?...

Max's steak dinner did a quick how-do-you-do? in her tummy and her feet took on pins and needles. The back of her neck went hot. She closed the drawer.

Max watched her reflection in the mirror. He said, "What is it?"

"Nothing."

Her hands were shaking before, but now they were out of control. Max was behind her, shirt off, wearing just his pants now. She watched him in the mirror as he pressed himself to her back and kissed her neck. She gave it to him, tilted her head far to the side to let his lips pluck and suckle on her. Now he was working her sweater up and taking her shirt with it. She raised her arms a little, put her hands over his. They were fine hands, graceful. Not weak, not powerful, somehow capable.

She whispered, "Do they have a guest room?"

"No."

"They don't?" That was weird; two people, two-story house, should have a guest room.

"They do, it's filled with boxes right now."

"Is there a bed in there?"

"We'd have to clear it."

The palms of her hands slick with wet, heart pounding hard and steady, a sex-hunger set to broil in her oven, she stared at Maggie's bed. A bed for three. "I can't, Max. Not in that bed..."

He sighed, his lips pursed. "Maybe we should stop."

"Oh no, we're not stopping," she said, putting her hands on his chest and smoothing them over the fine wool.

"It's the only bed," he said, recovering from the setback. This was an excellent test of a man's mettle and temper. he'd already handled the bad battery, but he couldn't call his father for advice on this one, she didn't think. "But I get it..."

She said, "Couldn't you have cleared the guest room today?"

"I thought it was presumptuous."

"Well, look at us now."

"You wouldn't have thought it was a little freaky to see I'd cleaned up the guest room knowing you were coming?"

"How would I know it was cleaned, Max, if I hadn't seen it before?"

“You’ve been here a lot... you might know...”

She rested her cheek against his chest, humor beginning to swell itself up inside her and choking off the sexual need. She preferred the sexual need right now. “I see your point, but you could have got away with it.”

His arms went around her, and she pressed her body against his, could feel his corduroy erection poking her stomach and wanted it inside her. “We’ll clear it now,” she said.

“But...”

“But what?”

Max said, “They’ll know I was with you if I clear it. Why wouldn’t I just sleep in the bed I always sleep in?”

“We could put it back together when we’re done...”

“We could go to the couch...”

“I want a bed, Max... Why would they care if you were with...” She let it go; her argument had a nasty endpoint—why would they care if you slept with someone else when you’re not part of the threesome anymore, Max? You’re a free agent, you’re off the team, you were asked to clear out your locker. That would have been hurtful. Max was holding on to whatever he had, and she had no idea what happened between them all. Three years in a poly relationship was a long time and there were surely deep stitches in his recent wound she best not start tugging on.

“Max,” she said, “how fast can you drive to my dorm?”

Home Field

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 19

IT TURNED out he could get there quite fast. A lot quicker than cleaning out the guest room. It took him only about six or seven minutes straight from Hilliard to the street parking on Holyoke Street, outside Lowell House. The whole while her in the front seat, sending Martina texts making sure she was on her plane, her other hand stroking Max's erection through his pants while she was saying, "She's not answering.... She's not answering, Max, I think she's on the plane..."

Max rolled through stoplights and stop signs. Harvard was dead this time of night, most of the students gone, headed to all their respective homes for the Christmas recess. The streets were plowed but wet; his Porsche only fishtailed one time, and that was coming fast around the corner on to Holyoke to find a lucky spot to park out front of the Malkin. Then she was grabbing change from his console, both of them scrambling out of the car, her throwing the change in a meter, all of it, not bothering to count, then Max walked the wrong way, to an iron-gated entrance she knew would be locked, and she had to call him back, saying, "This way, this way, shit, hurry..." and they hustled along the brick walk, went around to the front side door, then were zipping along the dead and quiet halls of Lowell. Holy shit, it was spooky. The place was empty but dimly lit. Thank God she wasn't alone. And she'd intended to sleep here tonight before her plane.

They ran up the stairs together, all the way to the fourth floor, and finally met a student coming down with her books clutched to her chest, wearing a sweatshirt and pajama pants. "Hey," she said quickly as they passed and then they were on the fourth floor, and she was leading the way,

jingling keys in her pocket and hand shaking as she shoved it in the hole—*oh boy, she couldn't wait for her turn!*—jiggling the door open, showing Max a finger to say wait. Then she was in, the room dark—she darted her head back out, saying, “Let’s go. She’s gone. She’s on her way back to Pennsylvania or wherever those people come from...”

Now Max was in, grabbing her with both hands and kicking the door closed behind him. They were kissing, and she was relieved to feel it. Hungry for him. They were right back to where they left off. Her heart racing, nipples aching to be touched, a throbbing need in her underpants. He was walking her back; they tumbled onto her dorm room bed. Max was over top of her finally—it was going to happen.

Eager Max was exciting, too. Like he’d been provoked the same way she had—both of them desperate for a good, hard shagging. They were on equal grounds. In fact, she had home field advantage, didn’t she? Max wasn’t so imposing here in her dorm room. Back in Maggie’s home (that probably cost a good seven figures) Max had been daunting. A mysterious puzzle piece in that libertine relationship. An unknown. Visions of secret societies and cocktail parties with theater masks and long flowing robes, perhaps a late night sacrifice (thank God she wasn’t a virgin!) were diminished here in the safety of her familiar room. Though she would have liked to do it on that beautiful bed. But what if the harness and ball gag were brought out?—was she ready for that? Not on their first night, she supposed.

This was good. This was fun. And while Max wasn’t as fearsome, he hadn’t lost his magic touch.

She told him: “You’ve got an amazing touch.”

Completely on the bed now, she was underneath him, he was between her knees, they kissed and bit, and Max had her skirt up, teasing his hand over her covered and very hungry sex.

Now he slowed, and their faces parted. Eyes working deep into hers, his hand left her mound, drifted higher, and she knew where it was headed. It made her hold her breath. With eyes locked on his all she could focus on was his deep dark eyes—the top of her brain tingled in electric anticipation. His hand crept over the top of her leggings, his skin warm against hers. His eyes narrowed. She took in one more squeak of breath, held it. Those graceful fingers of his eased under her panties and she felt ready to burst. Max had her thighs quivering; the last time she’d been this desperate to be

touched there, she'd never been touched there before. When his finger finally stroked over the center of her wet and swelled folds, her tummy fluttered and she moaned. A distinct tickling urge to urinate seized her, and she clamped his waist with her knees to chase it away.

He took her mouth again, but she squirmed her face away, grabbing at the shoulders of his coat and saying, "Get this off, Max, get it all off—I want to be naked."

Max rose to his knees, looming over her, eyes locked again—his eyes were magnetic; both of them ripped their coats off, breathing heavy... Then they were working on each other, pulling sweaters, undoing buttons, kissing, biting, sighing. Topless, they went solo again, him rolling back to get his pants off, her standing at the side of the bed and shimmying her skirt and leggings down. The only clothing remaining was her black bra—her good one from LaSenza—and they rejoined in the center of the bed on their knees, embracing and kissing; Max undid the snaps and traced her bra over her shoulders. Now they were naked...

Max worked her breasts, and she reached below to take his hardness. The guy was more than ready; his dick throbbed in her grip.

"You want to do this?" he whispered.

"I do," she said, biting on his shoulder. He made no further move. She paused, said, "Do you want to do this?"

"Yeah," he said, moving against her stiffly. "This is powerful..."

"I want it, Max," she assured him.

"Okay," he said, but his posture began to slump, and soon he was sitting on his heels.

"What's wrong?"

He said, "I left the condoms at the house."

"Aw, Max," she groaned, sat back on her heels, too. She ran a hand through her hair.

Now he was looking away, biting the inside of his cheek.

"Come on, Max," she urged him, reaching to take his wrist and pull him on top of her.

She lay back, and he got over her. He said, "Should I go back and get them?"

"I don't have time for that, Max. Please, let's go..."

"Without a condom?"

"It's okay," she told him.

“You’re on the pill?”

“I am,” she said, gripped his erection again and gave it gentle strokes.

Still he hesitated, looking in her eyes again with a strange sort of pleading. He said, “I’ve been with the same person for six years...”

“O-kay,” she said, brow lowering. Asshole. Good for you. I haven’t been with the same person for six years. I’m not going to give you herpes or anything...

Now he smiled and she could feel his tension melting as his body covered over hers. He said, “It’s just... Powerful...”

“Oh, ho ho, I’m your first...” She cooed, getting it now, understanding his trepidation. Sweetened by it.

“Yeah,” he laughed.

“Put it in me, please, Max, I want you so bad,” she said and ran her fingernails over his back.

Then he was sliding it inside her and it felt so good she laughed and arched her neck back, pushing her head into the pillow, sighing, “Oh God, oh God...”

“You feel so good...”

“Aw, Max, do it,” she whispered now, pumping her hips against his.

EVERYTHING NOT-MAGGIE CALLED out to him for attention; look at her skin, paler, creamier, freckled; look at her hair, look at that fiery hair that shone in the pale light, it didn’t turn black when it was dim; feel her lips, feel how they’re different, even her tongue is different; that softness, that luxurious soft feminine flesh; her sex sound was high and breathy and even tinged with that delightful accent; when he slid inside her his cock measured every difference inside her body as well; stickier, cooler than he’d expected, a softer embrace but a good grip when she flexed; those breasts mashed against him, and it had been a long time since he’d been with a girl with large breasts. Keely was all woman. A confident lover, one he just knew had no shyness about men. The way she moved against him showed him a woman who knew what she wanted from this; not demure, not bashful, almost proud of her own sexuality. It made him feel like an outsider, like he was auditioning for a role in her sex life; he got the

impression she'd gone through men and he wondered who in her life stood out as her sexual best. What turned a girl like this on? Was he even up to the task? Plenty of men must have competed to get this girl in bed; smart, beautiful, sexy, brash—she was way too valuable to be a shy little mouse like his Maggie had once been... God, even when he was blessed with a new and fantastic lover, cords of barbed wire still bound his heart to Maggie.

MAX SHOWED HER HIS STROKE; he was a slow and steady lover, doing it like he did foreplay. No rush, not looking to gush his seed. He teased. He kissed a lot while they made love. He liked to hold both her hands while they did it and she liked that. It was very loving. The love was obvious. And that was sad. She was the first girl he'd been with in four years and right now he was doing it like he'd been doing it previously. It broke her heart; this guy loved Maggie Becker but Maggie Becker loved another. Now she was the one reaping the reward; Maggie's castoff was a beautiful, sensitive man—and a lover. It was pure pleasure having him inside her. Maybe a little emotional since she could catch a glimpse of his loss in the way he moved over top of her, but that was beautiful too. And actually brought wet to her eyes and got her heart fluttering. She'd been in love twice in her life and she felt Max's hurt, and loved to be naked with him, sharing this.

It wasn't fucking; it was making love. He was incredible. Derek was hung, and a big, masculine guy. Six-two, almost two-hundred pounds and he liked to dominate her. Hurt her sometimes, too. And she liked that the first few times, then didn't appreciate the ache he left her with the next day. Even seemed to get off on making her bleed one time. After what felt like half an hour of making slow careful love with Max, a warm, blissful glow began to light up in her belly. Her sounds came then, and she was self-conscious. And she'd only begun. Derek brought her sounds fast—he fed off her sounds. Max coaxed them out of her. They were hers now, not the sound of suffering under a relentless pounding; but the sounds of sexual pleasure.

“Oh Max, oh Max,” she began.

“You feel so incredible,” he moaned.

“Oh God, you’re so good,” she said, her squeaks coming. Max sensed it. Could hear the high pitch of her voice, could hear the singing underneath her sighs. He liked it, too; every guy did, even though it embarrassed her. When she was a hefty teen, a few of the boys at The Bray taunted her with nicknames. They made her cry at night when they couldn’t see her; to their faces she fought back. Thank God for going to France; the boys she met there were appreciative. Max’s hips turned her taps, brought her joyful sounds in an unstoppable stream. Her thighs clamped him and she gasped and cried. The sounds of her voice were so loud in the quiet room and all she could think was without Lowell’s usual natural din, anyone staying over the holidays would hear her. No matter what floor they were on. Gathered up sheets were thrust into her mouth, and her hand covered over to clamp it down. Max’s thrusts picked up. Full bore strokes now, withdrawing and plunging his full length, holding, flexing. They got a rhythm; her canal gripped and squeezed, and when he was deep and flexing, she would curl her pelvic bowl forward, and his size was perfect to run that glans in an inch-long heavenly drag over her forward wall. The sheets were tugged from her mouth; she tore them away so she could kiss him. It was building—boy, was it building. Her skin grew slick, her breaths chugged, in between gasps for air she let herself squeal and cry from the pleasure.

Max was groaning, too, and it spurred her on; soon her thoughts were lost in the crashing waves of enveloping ocean sounds—her eardrums washing with sex-fueled fever-pulse. Max worked her like he knew what she wanted, giving her that hard tip to stroke her wall, withdrawing it and plunging, each thrust making her brain roll over like a dog wanting its belly petted. Then that tip-stroking...

The sound that burst from her when she came was a scream. Some blokes would clamp her mouth for fear of bringing the authorities, but Max let her loose it, let her celebrate, let her breathe, let her keep it for herself. But then he was grunting in her ear, telling her he was going to come. That got her ocean swell rising all over again. Her second orgasm was larger, and it crashed down over the first one. Max stiffened, body seized and trembling, his cock pushed all the way in her, and she knew what to do with it. Even though both their bodies were seized tight, their pelvises ground together. Max’s erection pulsed in her tight grip and she knew he was loosing his own liquid pleasure inside her.

The orgasm he gave her was large and enduring. It had her clutched to him, her nails digging in his upper arms while it rolled and rolled. She made funny squeaks now; every little slip of his penis inside her made some new sound babble from her. Both breathed heavy, both sweaty. Max rolled off to collapse on his back next to her, one hand up and covering his face.

“Wow,” she panted, “wow...”

“Yeah,” Max grunted into his hand.

Matt Damon's Bed

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 19

BAGS PACKED to fly home to Ireland tomorrow, most of her things were unavailable, but there was her bath towel hanging from a hook on the back of the door. She retrieved it, knowing but hating that Max would be watching her bright white ass right now. Gave him a sexy, carefree walk but inside she was not pleased. Towel snatched and gathered at her front she returned to the bed, climbed over him and lay at his side. She took one end and dried his penis which was still impressively hard, then left him to finish while she lay back and did some drying between her own thighs. Max's face was stony, but she left him alone. When nothing was said for a while she didn't like the idea of him with some inner turmoil when he should be a happy bloke after the ride they were just on. She cozied up against him, watching his forlorn face looking up at the ceiling, his hand on the top of his head clutching a swatch of his hair. Just blinking; she sought to cheer him up. "Powerful, you said, huh?"

He nodded.

"Is this where you're going to make fun of me noises?"

He chuckled silently, and she kissed his shoulder, watched his cheeks pull back with a nice smile.

She said, "What are you thinking about? Tell me something funny."

He still stared up at the ceiling, blinking, but eyes darting, trying to be clever. He said, "Trying to grasp how Matt Damon may have lay here staring at the same ceiling."

"It's amazing, isn't it?" she said, admiring his resilience. It would be powerful the first time you moved on after a long-lasting love. It was sad,

but the truth was the chances were good he still loved Maggie.

He said, "Do you think it's the same bed?"

"I bet it's the same old rotten bed."

"So we had sex on the same bed Matt Damon had sex on?"

She said, "We're practically celebrities."

Max frowned as though he were considering something serious. "I wonder if there will be a red carpet when we exit..."

She laughed, rocked herself against him. "What would you tell the cameras?"

"Wow, you're putting me on the spot."

"You're light on your feet, come on tell us what you would say."

"First, I'd thank God, I guess, I don't know, thank my mother, of course my mother... I guess all the people that got me here..."

Before he mentioned Maggie, she interrupted. "That's what athletes say after a game," she said, swatting his upper arm, "not an actor."

"You tell me then. What would you say?"

"Well, first I'd tell 'em I'm wearing Oscar de la Renta."

"That's your brand?"

"No, I just think it's cool to say." Then with flourish, and a touch of the French she picked up: "Oscar de la Renta."

"You speak French?"

"I know the dirty words and how to find drugs."

Now he was intrigued, rolling to his side and coming face to face with her. He touched her chin. "Were you a bad girl?"

She held a stony face, but her smile ruined it. "No. I went to an all-girl private school in a foreign country... I had to come up with ways to impress those bitches."

"Fifteen-year-olds with heroin habits are all the rage," he said.

"You're not wrong," she told him. "But I was fourteen. And scared shitless. But when the girls think you're into hard drugs, they leave you alone and yet simultaneously admire you. It's a sweet spot, hard to pull off unless you're a kook like me."

"You convinced them?"

"I was a little chunky for a heroin user but they believed me."

"You're not chunky now."

"I'm not fourteen."

"You're a woman."

“Almost.”

Now he caressed her cheek, those black eyes studying her, the quiet moment stretching long and thin. He said, “You are so beautiful.”

She lay her hand over his, said, “I know.”

He gave her a good laugh then settled it down, biting his lip and watching her again.

“What...?”

“You weren’t a bad girl?”

She shrugged.

He said, “I’ve been with only one person for... gosh, six years.”

“Maggie,” she said, then regretted saying her name out loud—they both knew it was Maggie.

“Maggie,” he said, then moved on, getting shockingly bold and asking: “How about you?”

She couldn’t believe he asked it. She said, “How about me what?”

He let it hang.

“Max, you don’t ask girls that.”

“I do.”

“I don’t want to answer.”

Max raised his eyebrows but watched her dozily. Picture of aloofness, he got closer and she thought he would persist wanting to know exactly what kind of red-headed slut she was. He kept his eyes on her, kissed her bare shoulder and got her nipples snapping tight again. She gave him a mean, warding off smile and he kissed her skin again.

Now he said, “Are you sure it’s this side?”

She frowned. “This side what?”

“I don’t think we can be sure.”

“Sure of what, Max?”

“Matt Damon, keep up, for crying out loud.” While she laughed, he kissed her breast, those plump lips working till he’d clamped her nipple.

She stroked his hair while he did, saying, “You mean he might have been in Martina’s bed?”

He nodded with her nipple pulled past his lips. He let it plop free, said, “We should fuck on her bed.”

Again she tried to keep a straight face, but it was hard with Max. She let him know: “Oh, Max, you don’t know how much I’d like that”—she sat up,

looking to the other side of the room—“and her bed would, too. I don’t think it’s seen any action at all this year.”

Max said, “Matt Damon’s bed deserves some action...”

Together they trotted the space between the two dorm room beds and hopped onto Martina’s, making it squeak and bump the wall. Both of them laughing and trying to be quiet which they didn’t need to do, but they were having fun doing something naughty and it heightened the excitement to hush their voices.

“Her poor unused bed,” she laughed, getting on her back with Max over her.

Max kissed her chest, bit the soft mash of her breasts and got her eyebrows rising as his kisses traveled lower.

“Well, all right, Mr. Milton,” she said, running nails through his dark hair and stroking his scalp. He tongued her navel on the way past and then he was where she was wet and eager. Before he began, he showed her his calm, steady demeanor again, not rushing in like her house was on fire, but rather taking a walk around and admiring her garden. She kept her lady trimmed but not shaved. A wiry thatch that ran in a sparse stripe straight down, growing thin and neat around her membranes. Max did the favor of not doing that Oh, the curtains match the drapes thing; three guys had done it and they’d gone home without parting gifts. Max kept his mouth shut, filling it with a wad of the creamy flesh of her inner thigh and suckling like he’d leave her with a mark. Then his fingers were stroking her, brushing her folds; she was engorged and ready, prepared for entry and his fingers teased and plucked at her most sensitive flesh. Her hands still worked his thick head of hair, and her hips worked her desperate part toward his mouth. He didn’t make her wait any longer, covering her pussy with those soft pillowy lips and using his tongue to work through her petals.

“Oh God,” she squeaked. Max was a hungry eater, not shy about his oral pleasure. In a few seconds he had her gasping, and she brought up a forearm to cover her face; bit her own flesh to stop her sounds—something she was used to doing. Most guys were reluctant, giving a meager pass of their tongue over to say they’d done it so you wouldn’t bug them later, throw it up in their face. Some guys avoided it altogether. But Max had no hang-ups, no reluctance. God, and he was doing it when she was dirty; doing it when he’d put his load in there already. For whatever reason that pushed her cart up over the peak and the next thing she’s rattling down the

tracks like a rollercoaster, letting him make her utter all sorts of sounds with her mouth free of arm flesh. She had her hands at her sides and grabbed fistfuls of Martina's sheets. Martina's sheets!—they were bad people doing perverted things. And she loved it...

MAX MADE her come with his mouth and took his time doing it. They made love immediately after. Long and drawn out again. She was worked in, and her sounds went quiet. But it was fun. It was good sex. Max was indeed no slouch. His hips worked in wonderful circles and lines, and his cock had a nice feel. Also no trouble in the hardness department. He wasn't number one, he didn't shoot to the top of the charts. But damn, there was something magical about sex with him. It was the timing he had, the endurance; and also the care he took. Very considerate, Maggie's cast off. Boy, Cole must be a real master. Though she knew he was.

The second round with him didn't make her come, but she enjoyed every second of it, thought even at one moment Max might do it for a third time but it dwindled. It was hilarious for a while considering the bed they were doing it in, picturing looking over Max's shoulder to see the door opening and wondering what Martina's face might do if she caught them. She would see Max's bare ass, maybe his bean bag jiggling as he pushed his thing in and out of her. Would she wave to Martina? That would be funny. Those thoughts were what made her come close to a third rocket ship, but alas, the ignition fizzled and in the end, Max came inside her again.

Now Max was withdrawing, his tip dribbling a little of his wet on her tummy. She wiped it with the back of her hand as he lay on his back next to her. With his hands rubbing his cheeks then smoothing back his hair, he made a groan.

She asked him What?

"I left that fire burning at the house."

Oh God. One of those. She hadn't seen that coming. "You did," she said, "A fire in the fireplace. The whole place might be gone by now."

"I know it's fine," he said, "it's just going to drive me crazy."

"Go on and go, though, I wouldn't want you worrying."

He turned his face to hers but now she was looking at the ceiling.

“Come back with me,” he said.

“Max, I’m in bed already.”

“No, you’re not,” he laughed.

“Good point,” she said, “but my bed’s a few feet away.”

He stroked her arm. “Come back with me, Keely.”

“Where would I sleep, Max? The couch? I have to go to the airport in ten hours.”

She could see him frowning. He lay back, too. He said, “I’ll just stay here.”

“What about the fire?”

“It’ll be fine.”

She said, “Your parking meter’s run out.”

“Don’t they have overnight parking?”

“Don’t think so,” she said.

He sat up now, ruffled his hair, looked around her room. “Do you want me to go?”

“I don’t care, Max. You left a fire going. Go tend it. Your car might be towed overnight, and how would you get to the airport then, dealing with that?”

“I could go put some change in the meter.”

“Max, just go. We’re both on planes tomorrow. I’ll see you when I come back in January.”

“Let’s put your things in the car, come back with me to Maggie’s house. I’ll drive you to the airport.”

“Max, it’s late, I don’t want to haul luggage at two in the morning out in the cold. Let me sleep. I’ll get a cab tomorrow, and I’ll call you when I get back from Ireland.”

Max sought to argue, but she knew he would go. It was what he wanted anyway, and he just didn’t like a girl calling him out on it. He vacillated, sighing and making sounds like he might form an argument, but he gave it up—one, he wanted to leave, two, he was probably getting the idea that she was good at arguing.

He rubbed his hair again, shook his head, climbed over her and crossed to the other bed. The towel was left there, and he dried his pecker off and then offered it up to her. She held out a hand, and he leaned and plopped it in her grasp. She dried herself watching him dress and neither of them spoke.

Once he was clothed but hadn't got his coat on yet, he paused, sat on the bed with a heavy thump and looked at her.

She stared back.

He said, "So I'm just going to go?"

"Go, Max," she said.

"Are you mad?"

"No," she laughed. Lied. "It makes sense. Tell me it doesn't."

He gave her an eye roll, and looked sullen, pouted lips, like a kid outside the principal's office.

She said, "I'll call you when I get home from Ireland."

"Will you?"

"I'll call you," she said.

Now he came to her, lowered his face over hers and kissed her. She gave him stiff lips. He didn't like it, took her hand and squeezed her fingers. He said, "I really wish you'd come back with me."

She kept his gaze then, saw a glimmer that she might be mad for no reason, said, "It's late, Max."

He nodded, studying her face, his lower lip tugged under his front teeth. His thumb rubbed her fingers. He said, "I had an amazing night tonight, Keely."

"It was good, Max," she said, tugging sheets to cover her breasts, "and thank you for dinner."

"Call me when you get back. Promise me," he said.

"I'll call," she said, covering herself further under Martina's sheets.

Max watched her speculatively while he donned his coat. He paused at the door, said, "Have a good Christmas."

"You too," she said, and then he was gone.

She took her time getting out from under the sheets, finding a sweatshirt and cotton PJ shorts, putting them on and going to the dormer window, tucking her cold hands up under her sleeves. Elbows on the sill, she waited and watched; soon there was a dark figure down there coming out onto the sidewalk, turning up his collar. Her eyes followed the figure as he made his way toward the Malkin then she couldn't see him anymore. After another long moment, she saw the snowbank light up in red from his taillights, saw frigid exhaust fumes hang heavy in the air before whispering away. Then he was gone, and it was dark.

She should have gone with him, gone to the house and accepted a ride, but she had a temper and now it was too late, anyway.

NEVER FELT OLDER, never felt like such a flop. Had he even impressed her? He geared down turning on to Plympton, heading back to Maggie's. Twenty-four years old was too young to feel out of the game. But Keely was twenty-one, young, foreign, vibrant, and was already resisting the prickle of his weirdness. Should he have told her he was in a three-way relationship? He'd wanted to be honest since a lack of honesty was what had ruined him in the past. But now that revelation felt pronounced. Keely didn't want to be in Maggie's bed. Didn't want to return to Maggie's house to sleep with him. And what does he do after she'd wowed him with incredible, passionate sex?—talk about Maggie's house and his duty to tend the fire.

But he'd told her about his relationship with Maggie for another reason than pure honesty. The truth was important, yes, but it was also respect. And why did he respect her? Because he was aware now of a deep kindling care growing inside for this red-headed kook. His own past was his enemy now and the urge to deceive was strong. Why couldn't he have just cleaned Cole's shit out of Maggie's guest room this afternoon...?

Logan

SUNDAY, DECEMBER 20

FIVE AND A HALF hours later she was at the Woolly Lamb Bagel Café cursing herself for her petulant behavior. To make matters worse, the barista at the to-go was waiting to hear what she wanted in her coffees. Two creams in hers, that was easy—but how did Max take his? All she could think now was how she’d zipped him with that little test the night he’d come to confess to her his darkest secret; that he was engaged in a three-way relationship. Why did he come to offer this explanation?—oh, because you move a little fast, Keely, remember when you kind of sucked him off on his couch when he wasn’t really expecting it? You’re lucky he was nice enough to come and explain, nice enough to cook you dinner after you later forced the love of his life to expel him from the warm fold of their relationship. Least you could do was let him worry in peace about the fire he’d left burning in his ex-girlfriend’s fireplace.

“Uh... two creams, no... uh, maybe—”

The barista said, “On the side...?”

“Yes, please. On the side, please.” How embarrassing. “Wait—for both. Both black, cream and sugar on the side, please.” How ingenious, how diabolical.

A minor victory but one she would take this morning.

When the coffees were ready, she was asked: “Do you want a tray?”

“I’ve got me mitts,” she said, holding them up and wiggling her fingers underneath.

A brisk walk through Harvard Square, through the cold and the blue still-dark, and soon she was on Hilliard with her cheeks tingling from the

light snow.

Max was gone—it was too late. His car not there, the guy had gone off to do errands or booked an earlier flight when his date had treated him sulkily. Her heart sank, and she whined an Oh no, quickening her step in the off chance...

...He *was* still there, his Porsche just pulled deep into the driveway so she couldn't see till she was closer. A nice tingling relief washed up from her feet and she began a trot, still careful not to slip on the icy and uneven old sidewalk. That would be a fine way to end up this morning and she probably deserved it, ass over tea kettle with her skirt up around her ears and nine dollars worth of coffee in the gutter.

Only she made it safely, mounted the three steps to Maggie's front door and rang the bell before she lost her nerve. What she really deserved was to have Max answer the door, Maggie and Cole looming in the background wearing robes after a long night of three-way make-up sex; a loving reunion where his old lovers treated him with respect. She was ready to press the bell again, but willing to give him more time; with coffees in her hands she couldn't check her watch but it must be a little before eight.

Movement behind the glass then, a figure coming down the steps and around the newel post, heading her way. Then Max opened the door, looking bewildered and sleepy. Guy slept in a Farmingham T-shirt and plaid PJ bottoms. His hair shot off in thick disobedient clumps.

She held the coffees up, said, "Is it too late to hitch a ride to the airport?"

IN THE KITCHEN they set their coffees down and Max studied her. "You could have called, I would come to pick you up. You didn't bring your bags..."

She shrugged, tried to ease the tightness from her expression, but averted her eyes from his, letting them drift to watch his hands as he peeled the lid off his coffee cup and tore a packet of sugar. *Black with sugar...? Was that it...?* She said, "If it's all right, we can pick them up on the way..."

"Of course," he said, pulling back the foil off a creamer. *One cream, one sugar...*

She said, “Is it too early? Did I wake you?”

“You woke me, but it’s not too early.” He took a sip of his coffee. One cream, one sugar. Got it.

Now she looked around the kitchen; the sun was warming up the light, and it was pushing the gray-blue away and making the room feel warm and hopeful. She said, “Is it all right if I use your loo?”

Max sipped his coffee, still studying her. “Sure, yeah, you can.”

“Thanks,” she said, tucking her chin down and leaving the kitchen. In the hall, instead of going to the front door and using the powder room, she mounted the steps and quietly made her way to the second floor. Stocking feet whispering along the polished wood she skated her way down the hall and into Maggie’s bedroom where she would now prove to Max she was a big girl. The sheets on that massive black leather bed were tossed, oversized decorative pillows sent to the floor, a divot on a huge cushy one where Max had been laying his head.

Now she was moving fast, whisking her sweater over her head and pulling off her shirt without unbuttoning it. This was crazy, so crazy, but she wanted to do it so bad. There were a few blokes she’d proved too much for, and they’d ended up calling her a crazy bitch, but fuck it—was the way it was. Tights scrolling down her legs, she pulled her feet free, got her panties off as well and now she was totally naked in the brightening light, tip-toeing around to the far side of the bed and then crawling under the covers, beating a head hole into a pillow for her to use, thumping her noggin down and watching the doorway for Max to come.

Ten minutes she waited. Ten minutes watching the hands on the bedside clock whir around, that minute one taking its sweet time. What a gentleman, not coming looking for her; fear he might interrupt a lengthy poop she was dropping in Maggie’s toi-toi and embarrass her.

Finally she heard the creak of the steps as he’d found the powder room empty and came upstairs looking for this weird girl he’d had sex with last night. Now she was squirming under Maggie’s sheets—very silky—trembling with anticipation and stifling a giggle. His shadow began to loom and stretch down the hallway wall she could see through the open door. She closed her eyes and nuzzled herself into the bedding, waiting.

She could hear her Max standing in the doorway and breathing, could hear him lean against the frame. She let her eyes open and flutter in theatrical waking, eyes glazing with fake sleepy bewilderment. “Oh, Max,”

she sighed, seeing him smiling—at least one half of his mouth. “Good morning. Do I smell coffee?”

His head eased aside as his eyes continued to study this strange pale creature. He thunked his skull on the frame, smiling, crossing his arms. He said, “You do. I put a pot on.”

“You’re a doll,” she said, stretching her arms out over the sheets, let him see she wasn’t wearing a thing. He saw. Now he was intrigued, eyebrows raising, smirk deepening. “I slept so wonderfully. Are you coming back to bed?”

He moved off the frame, coming to her with his arms folded, but very pleased. He sat down and looked over his shoulder at her; she stroked her hand on his back. He said, “I didn’t wake you, did I?”

She shook her head no, smiled, said, “Come back to bed.”

He was a little tentative; she was acting strange and all, sweet, but it was that weird thing where she might surprise him with a butcher knife under the covers. She raised the sheets to show him she was unarmed. And naked. His eyes went up and down her body, what he could see, and as cool as he might want to act about it, his eyes widened.

Max took off his shirt, lay back on the mattress then scooted his legs under the sheets, rolling to face her.

She kissed him. He was receptive. She said, “What time is it?”

“Eight.”

“It’s still early. We don’t have to leave for... maybe two hours.”

“We still have to run over to your place to grab your things,” he said, running a hand over her arm.

“They’re ready to go at the door. Won’t take a minute.”

He said, “We’ll have to have breakfast.”

“We will,” she said, her hands under the sheets untying the knot at the top of his pajama pants. “Do they have bacon, do you think?”

“Fridge is bare. We ate all our dinner up, no leftovers.”

“I might’ve introduced you to an Irish Fry.”

“I would’ve liked it,” he said.

“Another time.”

“I can’t wait,” he said, and now his lips sought hers and they kissed. She pushed his pants down, and he got his legs out of them. An arm snaked around her waist and he gripped her to him. “You feel so good.”

She said, “You do, too. I like waking up with you.”

“I like waking up with you.”

She kissed his neck, and he rubbed her bare back. Her hard nipples dragged over his body and his growing erection pressed her hip. She said, “We have our coffees, maybe you take me to eat somewhere we can sit down and have a mimosa before we go to the airport.”

“I’m starving.”

“That still gives us some time.”

“We have to shower.”

“We can do it together.”

“Saves time.”

“It does.”

Now she rolled her body overtop his, and he went to his back. She pressed herself against him, felt his warm skin, felt his eager erection against her stomach. She said, “I wish we weren’t flying away today, I wish we had more time.”

“I have to go,” he said, taking her earlobe in his mouth.

“I do, too.”

He said, “Shoot, we’ll have to tidy the house—”

“Put the sheets in the laundry...”

He chuckled, looked in her eyes and grasped an ass cheek in each of his hands and he hugged her tight against him. It did a funny thing in her heart.

She kept his gaze a long time, rolling her hips against his—not sexually, though they were both aroused and naked, but in a weird, caring, comforting way; like they’d been apart a long time and missed each other.

She said, “Will you just relax and enjoy it this time?”

“What...?”

She kissed his neck, his collar, her body inching down his. “You know what I’m going to do.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah, oh. Don’t be weird this time.”

He smiled, but she saw an excitement in his eyes. “I’ll enjoy it.”

“I’d like that. I go to a lot of effort.”

“I swear I will.”

She kissed down his chest, over his stomach, paused, smiling, delaying, coming back up to his face. “Are you going to call me from Michigan?”

“If you want me.”

“I’d like it.”

“I’ll call you,” he said, rubbing her arms.

She nodded, kissed down again, all the way to his navel, getting under the sheets; then coming back out again. “Would you call me tomorrow, let me know you got home okay?”

He chuckled, sighed, “I’ll call you tomorrow.”

“Good,” she said, watching his eyes, nodding.

Her kisses worked downward, and she didn’t know if she’d tease him again. But when she got to his navel, she decided to keep going, kissing her way through his scruff of pubic hair, her hand taking his upright erection and pointing it out of the way. She kissed inside his thighs, let the sheet cover her over in darkness, took both his balls in her mouth and rolled them around, let her tongue swath over their shapes. Then she was kissing up the underside of his cock, getting it wet and slippery, flicking her tongue as she went, tickling the underside of his glans. Her mouth enveloped him and she felt his legs writhing, moving up and down as she began to bob.

Then the sheet was whisked up, and she was flooded with light. She looked up to Max, his penis fully in her mouth. He was trying to talk; trying to be funny while in ecstasy; he said, “What’s the time difference between Ireland and Michigan?—when’s a good time to call you?”

She laughed so hard she blurted air around his cock, puffing her cheeks out. She tugged the sheet down and turned her face away; no matter how pretty you were it probably wasn’t a flattering look guffawing with a penis in your mouth.

Max’s belly jumped up and down as he laughed, enjoying his dumb joke she’d started, but it wasn’t long before he wasn’t laughing anymore and she had his knees working up and down, the insides of his thighs opening and closing against her ears. Her hand caressed his balls, gave them the occasional squeeze, but mostly it was old fashioned full-tilt *head* that got the job done; chicken-heading, keeping it simple, but her secret ingredient of persistence making the magic happen. She was very pleased when he erupted finally, and this morning she let him do it in her mouth. They were on much better terms, why not go for it...

She took her time gathering herself, getting his semen down before she showed her face again, kissing her way back up to daylight and laying next to him. She drew a circle on the point of his chin, studying his profile,

watching those lips as he panted, satisfied. She said, “And here I thought you didn’t like blow jobs.”

THIS BED HAD BEEN his sexual home for the last two years. A prison in its own way, looking back and now that it was over. But here he was restored as a man, and he had this odd, pale creature in his arms to thank. Just when he’d thought he was lost, she called out to him from the fog and helped him find the shore. It was a risky thing sailors did, listening to the lure of a woman’s voice, and there would be times in the future with Keely where she would drive him to the brink of madness—but he was right to heed her call. She would take him on a journey that would heal all the self-inflicted wounds he’d whipped on his back over his love for Maggie Becker. She would make him whole, she would lash together the parts that no longer seemed to match up, and more: she would astound him with her own proclivities and her curiosity of his dark sexuality. But she would also bring him to his knees with the hurt he craved—her demons would taunt his.

With Keely in his arms, both of them at the edge of sleep, this future was unknown to him. All he knew was he wanted to blow off Christmas with his family and stay in this bed for a week and get to know everything about Keely O’Mearáin. He wouldn’t. It wasn’t wise to be crazy this early. She was cool, and he could be cool too. She would go to Ireland, he would go to Grand Rapids. But he would count the seconds until they were both back here on the east coast.

Today they would rise and they would shower. He would fuck her again, try her from behind while standing. In fact, the mere thought of her sex voice in the glass and tile confines of the walk-in shower were renewing the hardness between his legs. Afterward, he would buy her a breakfast and pick up her bags and they would go to the airport together. Sunlight fell through the window onto his eyes-closed sleepy face and he smiled, thinking how wonderful it would be when they kissed farewell.

He would have someone to come home to.

To be continued in Book Two...

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Afterword

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